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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PM TO ADDRESS THE NATION TODAY



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda is set to address the nation on Tuesday. According to the Prime Minister's Secretariat, he will be addressing the nation from 5:00 pm.

He is scheduled to address the nation, marking the completion of one

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PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Students walking home from their school in Thaha Municipality of Makawanpur district.

Major parties agree to advance TRC Bill

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec 25:

A meeting of the top leaders of three major political parties held at the Prime Minister's official residence in Baluwatar this evening ended with an agreement to pass the Bill on Commission on Investigation of Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation (TRC) from the upcoming winter session of the Federal Parliament.

Parliamentary approval of the TRC Bill will be a breakthrough in completing the remaining tasks of the country's peace process.

According to the PM's Personal Secretary Ramesh Malla, the top leaders of the three major political parties agreed to advance the bill on Commission on Investigation of Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation, which is in the parliamentary committee and pass it from the winter session of the parliament with priority for making the laws relating to transitional justice.

Talking briefly to the media after the meeting, CPN (UML)'s parliamentary party whip Mahesh Bartaula said the top leaders agreed to make victim-centric laws.

"The UML is ready to go for a consensus if we are to make the victim-centric laws. The PM has expressed his readiness to address this issue from the winter session," Bartaula mentioned.

Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chair Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba, CPN (UML) Chair KP Sharma Oli, Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka, Minister for Law Dhanraj Gurung and other leaders of the three parties were present at the meeting summoned by the Prime Minister.

Smooth supply of fertilizer elates farmers

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The government has been giving priority to the supply of chemical fertilisers and other agricultural inputs in a bid to increase production and productivity of the agriculture sector.

In a year after the formation of the present government under the leadership of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on December 25, 2022, the government imported almost 500,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers.

According to the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development, the government has distributed more than 400,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers to the farmers in a year.

With the improvement in the supply of chemical fertilisers, the farmers across the country have been able to get the chemical fertilisers as per their needs during the time of paddy plantation and to grow winter crops like wheat and potatoes, said Sabnam Shivakoti, spokesperson for the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development.

Goma Adhikari of Panchkhal Municipality-7, Kavrepalanchowk, said that they received the required amount of chemical fertilisers for potato cultivation.

Recalling the acute shortage of chemical fertilisers during the paddy cultivation time in the summer and to grow potatoes in winter last year, she said that the farmers did not face any shortage of chemical fertilisers this year.

Last year, the farmers not only in Panchkhal but also elsewhere were forced to stand in queue for hours to get 5-10 kg of fertilisers.

"As farmers, we expect an easy supply of chemical fertilisers, seeds and tools and proper management of markets to sell our produce. So, I want to give thanks to the government for managing a smooth supply of chemical fertilisers. We also expect subsidies for these goods," she said.

One Year of Government

Even though the government has increased the supply of chemical fertilisers, the present supply is not enough. The government study showed that at least 700,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers are required annually.



The government has allocated Rs. 30 billion to provide subsidies to the farmers on chemical fertilisers.

Shivakoti said that the procurement process for chemical fertilisers would be improved and the supply and distribution process of the fertilisers would be made systematic and transparent.

The process of establishing a chemical fertiliser factory within the country has also moved ahead.

Development on crop seeds, livestock vaccination

According to the Ministry, the seed production cycle has been expanded by establishing 13 resource centres and producing 1,000 tonnes of source seeds of various crops.

In the last year, 22 varieties of various crops including rice, wheat, corn, and vegetables have been registered for source seeds and the seeds of six varieties have been released.

To provide technical services at farmers' doorstep, 397 people have been mobilised as agricultural graduates, veterinary doctors, agricultural technicians and animal service specialists at the local levels through conditional grants.

According to the Ministry, the area to cultivate fruits, vegetables, potatoes, coffee and spices has been expanded to 2,412 hectares by providing subsidies to attract farmers towards cash crop farming.

The minimum support price of rice has been fixed at Rs. 3,198 per quintal for coarse rice and Rs. 3,362 per quintal for medium rice and accordingly, 37,000 tonnes of paddy have been purchased through Food Management and Trading Company and 15,000 through cooperatives at the minimum support price.

The minimum purchase price of sugarcane this year has also been fixed at Rs. 635 per quintal.

During the year, around 181,965 crop and livestock insurance policies have been issued and crops and livestock worth Rs. 50 billion have been insured, according to the ministry.

A total of Rs. 2.12 billion, including Rs. 1.96 billion under livestock insurance and Rs. 159 million under agriculture insurance has been paid.

According to the ministry, the vaccination programme was conducted by producing 53.8 million doses of 13 different types of vaccines for the control of infectious diseases of livestock.

In the meantime, the government has facilitated the import of 1.37 million doses of vaccine to control lumpy skin disease, and around 351,000 animals have been vaccinated against the lumpy skin disease.

Rules, regulations and standards

According to the ministry, after approving the (First Amendment) Standard, 2079 regarding providing relief for items destroyed during bird flu control, an amount of Rs. 580 million

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I will do justice to all party leaders: Deuba

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Dec. 25

Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the party will maintain full justice while distributing the election tickets.



Inaugurating the NC Tanahun district conference in Damauli on Monday, Deuba said justice would be given to those who did not get the election tickets earlier and those who were not getting them now would get it in the future.

Deuba also inaugurated the BP Memorial Building constructed by the NC Tanahun District Committee.

Stressing for unity in the party by sacrificing differences, he said to build the party-unity strong, justice would be provided while distributing tickets in the election of the National Assembly.

Deuba also underlined the need for consensus among political parties stating that no party could garner a majority in the election due to the inclusive proportional system provisioned in the constitution.

"We have to strengthen the Federal Democratic Republic system by forging consensus," he said.

Deuba said although the NC did not garner a majority in the parliament due to the constitutional provision, it emerged as the largest party and it should move ahead with reconciliation.

"It is difficult for a single party to garner a majority in the parliament due to constitutional provision introduced to ensure representation of all castes, genders, communities and geographies, so there is no alternative to developing consensus with other parties to form the government," he said.

Deuba further stressed consensus between political parties to conclude the peace process and the crises facing the country.

Likewise, Deuba released a souvenir published by the NC Tahanun.

In the souvenir, the names of 1847 persons who donated to build the BP Memorial Building were mentioned. The building that covers an area of 8 aana of land was constructed at Rs. Rs. 17,200,000.

He also garlanded the BP's statute reaching BP Park in Byas Municipality-3, from where BP Koirala, in 1979, announced that the status of all Nepali should be made the same with one residence, a milking cow, a pair of oxen, enough food for morning and evening, money to educate children and buy medicines.

High level body sought to resolve power supply issue

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) has demanded formation of a high-level commission to resolve the arrears disputes of trunk and dedicated lines.

Issuing a press statement regarding a long-standing dispute related to the dedicated and trunk lines arrears on Monday, the FNCCI demanded a powerful commission to resolve the dispute between the Authority and the industrialists.

FNCCI showed its serious attention to the fact that power lines of industries were cut without resolving the disputes related to the payment of dedicated and trunk lines connected to industries.

The FNCCI demanded that a commission, having representatives also from private sector, should be formed to give an impartial opinion after analysing the past studies, current situation and Time of the Day (TOD) metres, among others.

The Federation has requested the Nepal Electricity Authority and other related agencies to reconnect the electricity supply of the industries Until a final decision is made on the issue. It also requested the NEA not to cut the lines of other industries.

"If this issue is not addressed immediately, industries will be shut down, and it will affect employment and revenue. During the current economic recession, the Federation is confident that the government will take initiatives to solve the problem by taking the issues of the private sector seriously," said the FNCCI.

Meanwhile, the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) has emphasised that the dispute over dedicated and trunk lines, which has been going on for a long time, should be resolved immediately through discussion rather than inviting a tussle.

Organising a press conference on Monday evening, President of CNI Rajesh Kumar Agrawal said that the disputes on the arrears of dedicated lines should be addressed adopting a middle way.

He said that it was not appropriate

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Newar community marks Yomari Punhi today

BY SUSHMA MAHARJAN
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Yomari Punhi is a major festival of the Newars in Kathmandu. 'Yomari' means favourite confection in the Newari language. It is celebrated annually on the full moon of the Nepali month of Mangsir.

On the occasion, the people of the Newar community prepare a special delicacy called yomari, a closed cone-shaped cuisine made of rice flour filled with molasses and sesame seeds.

The festival also marks the end of the harvesting season.

Sunita Maharjan, a local from Kilagal, said that she celebrates by cleaning her house, performing puja and offering yomari to the god and goddess early in the morning. Afterwards, she prepares a feast for her family.

According to Maharjan, yomari is made from the flour of the first harvested paddy and offered to the paddy bhakari, a traditional container for storing food grains. This is done with prayers for the harvested grain to be sufficient for the family throughout the year. She said that people celebrate by performing 'tyo-si-tyo', a tradition, where groups visit houses in the



community singing folklore.

Upon their arrival, the house owners gift them yomari, fruits and other items and in return the group bless them with good fortune and life, Sunita said.

According to her, the tyo-si-tyo carries traditional and cultural values.

She said, "Newar people value sharing food and celebrating festivals with family and friends. Historically, yomari was a rare food prepared once a year. Thus, people used to play tyo-si-tyo and share yomari in the community."

Furthermore, making yomari is considered a way to showcase skills of housewives. Yomari's unique cone shape featuring a head and tail allows for artistic expression. The tail can be elongated and the head can be shaped into figures like birds, one horn and two horns or even flattened.

There is a belief that the longer the tail of the yomari, the longer the day will become from that day onward. Additionally, the delicacy is nutritionally valued since it is made of rice flour and sweet ingredients that help generate body heat.

Meanwhile, some people now celebrate the festival at their convenience due to busy lifestyles.

Sahayog Ranjit, a local, said that his family celebrates when they find free time. He said at least one festival falls every month in a Newar community. He said, "I and my family members are employed. We don't have enough time to prepare for the feast. Thus, we call a gathering of the closed family when we have free time and celebrate it together."

At the meantime, many organisations have started organising rallies and fairs to celebrate and preserve the festival. On the occasion, people dressed in Newari attire gather at Basantapur to participate in the events.

This year, a rally is being organised from Basantapur. It will pass through Tengal,, Chhetrapati, Thahiti, Ason, Indra Chowk, Ombahal, Lagan and Maru before returning to Basantapur.

Similarly, 'Dhulikhel Yomari Festival' is scheduled for Tuesday in Dhulikhel of Kavrepalanchowk. Dhulikhel Lacchi Women Group chairperson Diwa Byaju informed that a yomari jatra will be taken from Chochhen Tole to Narayansthan in Dhulikhel.

Cargo train to Biratnagar yet to make 2nd trip after June inaugural



BY SASHIDHAR PARAJULI
Biratnagar, Dec. 25

It has been six months since Nepal welcomed the cargo train that arrived in Biratnagar from India. The train, carrying raw materials for Aarti Steels Pvt. Ltd., came at Biratnagar Customs on June 2 this year

Since it was jointly inaugurated with high importance by Nepal's Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the former's India visit, many hoped that the train would operate regularly between the two countries. But after that inaugural trip, the cargo rail never returned.

Local industrialists say that it is because of the weaknesses of the Nepali side when signing the railway route agreement with India. But the Biratnagar Customs Office says the rail has not come again because traders have not wanted to bring any goods through it.

On June 1, a day before the train service was inaugurated, the ministers for Industry, Commerce and Supplies from Nepal and India signed a bilateral trade agreement that purportedly stipulated that only chemical fertiliser, coal, clinker and cement could be brought to the Jogbani border point from the Kolkata port. "This route has been separated for bulk cargo.

That is why traders have not been able to import goods by this train," Rakesh Surana, president of the Chamber of Industries, Morang, told The Rising Nepal. "We have not been able to utilise this train because we cannot bring raw materials and other items through this route."

But Gyanendra Raj Dhakal, chief of the Biratnagar Customs Office, flatly disagrees. "Nothing is stopping the cargo rail from coming to the integrated checkpoint at Biratnagar.

The infrastructure is good and both we and the Jogbani officials are prepared to clear all goods that come through. So, how can anyone claim that the treaty has prevented them from bringing goods?" he questioned, claiming that businesses had not even booked the train.

"How will anything come without them even trying to book the train? We stand ready to facilitate the process and clear any hurdles," Dhakal said.

This reply seemed to frustrate Surana though. "We used to bring 90 per cent of our goods from the Kolkata port. But now, they have made it a bulk cargo-only route. So, how and why will we book the cargo rail from there? Our government signed the agreement without understanding its provisions," he criticised.

But Dhakal rejected the authenticity of the 90 per cent figure. "It is not accurate to say that 90 per cent of goods came from Kolkata. Many traders had already shifted to Vishakhapatnam and it is easier to import larger quantities from there."

It is worth noting that the cargo train brought items other than chemical fertiliser, coal, clinker and cement on its first trip. Also, Dhakal said that the bulk cargo provision only applied to materials imported from third countries and that raw materials of all kinds could be brought by the cargo rail if they originated in India.

Nevertheless, Dhakal said that they had written to higher authorities to address the industrialists' concerns three months ago. "But the present provisions do not stop them from using the cargo train."

NAC handling Thai Airways' ground services



PHOTO: TRN
An image showing the ground handling of an aircraft generated by Microsoft Bing Image Creator.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) has thanked Thai Airways and the government of Thailand for trusting it to provide the Airways with ground handling services at Kathmandu's Tribhuvan International Airport (TIA).

Issuing a statement on Sunday, the NAC formally expressed its gratitude and emphasised that it had been certified by the International Air Transport Association's Safety Audit for Ground Operations (ISAGO). ISAGO is an industry programme for the global oversight of ground handling service providers.

Thai Airways used to handle its ground operations at the TIA itself. However, on October 29 this year, it signed an agreement with the NAC to have the latter handle its ground services, which typically include aircraft cleaning, catering, ramp service, air cargo, and check-in services, among others.

As per the statement, Thai Airways also gave NAC 80 of its ground support equipment on December 16. The Government of Nepal had authorised the equipment transfer on July 19.

China allows online games to control losses

AP
Bangkok, Dec.25

China's press and publications authority has approved 105 new online games, saying it fully supports the industry after proposed curbs caused massive losses last week for investors in major games makers.

The National Press and Publication Administration issued a statement on its WeChat social media account Monday saying the approvals by the Game Working Committee of China Music and Digital Association were "positive signals that support the prosperity and healthy development of the online game industry."

Tencent's "Counter War: Future" and NetEase's "Firefly Assault" were among games approved.

Draft guidelines for curbs on online gaming had caused share prices of video game makers like Tencent and Netease to plunge on Friday, causing losses of tens of billions of dollars and dragging Chinese benchmarks lower.

The administration's guidelines said online games would be banned from offering incentives for daily log-ins or purchases. Other restrictions include limiting how much users can recharge and issuing warnings for "irrational consumption behavior."

On Friday, Netease's Nasdaq-traded shares fell 16.1% while it's Hong Kong-traded shares sank 25%. Tencent's closed 12% lower. Huya Inc., a smaller online games maker, lost 10.7% on the New York Stock Exchange. Overall, the companies lost tens of billions of dollars in market value.

Hong Kong's market was closed Monday for the Christmas holiday. Share prices in Shanghai were flat. The Press and Publication Administration said that in 2023, 1,075 game version numbers had been issued, of which 977 were domestically produced and 98 were imported.

It also cited a "2023 China Game Industry Report" that it said showed sales revenue for the domestic online games market exceeded 300 billion yuan ($42 billion) in 2023, with the number of people playing the games reaching 668 million.

"The Game Working Committee hopes that member units will take this opportunity to launch more high-quality products, promote high-quality development of the online game industry, and contribute to promoting cultural prosperity and development and building a culturally powerful country," it said.

Budget implementation in Karnali at 9.68 per cent in five months

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Dec. 25

The Karnali Provincial Government has spent only 9.68 per cent of the budget in the first five months of the current fiscal year. Only Rs. 3.23 billion of the total budget allocation has been spent by December 16, 2023.

The provincial government has presented a budget of Rs. 33.37 billion for the current fiscal year 2023/24. Looking at the state of budget implementation, the Karnali government looks weaker than last fiscal year.

The government had spent 9.80 per cent of the budget during the first five months of the last fiscal year 2022/23. Coming to the second term of the provincial government, instead of improvement in the implementation, the performance of the current government in budget implementation has not improved.

Because of this, the performance of the provincial government is being questioned. In the current fiscal year, the budget under recurrent expenditure is Rs. 13.80 billion, while the capital budget is Rs. 19.57 billion. However, the government is poor in implementing the development budget.



FILE PHOTO: TRN
Karnali Provincial Assembly.

By mid-December 2023, while the government spent 16.42 per cent of the budget under the recurrent budget, only 4.94 per cent of the capital budget was implemented. The condition of the budget implementation of the ministries which are given great importance and priority has been very weak.

According to the Province Financial Comptroller Office, Karnali Province, the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Urban Development, which has an annual budget of more than Rs. 10.11 billion, including recurrent and capital budget, has been able to implement only 5.32 per cent in five months.

Out of it, the ministry has spent only 4.60 per cent under capital budget heading and 27.11 per cent under recurrent heading. This ministry has the highest development budget of Rs. 9.83 billion for the current fiscal year.

Another ministry with a higher development budget is Water Resources and Energy Development. This ministry has spent 5.89 per cent of both the recurrent and capital budget. The Ministry, which has important development plans such as hydroelectricity and drinking water, is not able to pay much attention to budget implementation.

This ministry has a development budget of more than Rs. 3 billion.

Similarly, the Office of the Chief Minister and Council of Ministers spent only 3.38 per cent of its budget, the Ministry of Finance 25.66 per cent, the Ministry of Industry, Tourism, Forestry and Environment 11.82 per cent, the Ministry of Land, Management, Agriculture and Cooperatives 9.51 per cent, the Ministry of Law 15.62 per cent and the Ministry of Social Development 16. 19 per cent in the first five months.

According to Pushkar Pulami, the Information Officer of the Province Financial Comptroller Office, Karnali Province, the Office of the Chief Minister and Council of Ministers, which has a budget of more than Rs. 1.3 billion, is not able to spend even 1 per cent of its development budget.

Kalika fair to end today

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Hetauda, Dec. 25

A two-day Kalika fair has begun at Namtar of Makwanpur district since Monday. The fair that has begun on the Kalika temple premises in Namtar of Kailash Rural Municipality Ward No. 9 will conclude on the day of the full moon day on Tuesday at the Kalika temple by sacrificing a he-goat.

In 1993, the temple was swept away by a flood in the Namtar market area. The stone in the place was considered as Syarse Kalika Devi and is worshipped by people.

Bhuwan Singh Ghalan, ward chairman of Ward No. 9 of Kailash Rural Municipality, said that the temple is being constructed with the help of the Bagmati Province Government, rural municipality, ward office and the devotees.

He said that only works to give an attractive look to the temple and build a compound wall are left. At the place from where the temple was swept away by the flood of 1993, idols of Kalika and Ganesha were carved on a large stone and consecrated in November with the help of doors.

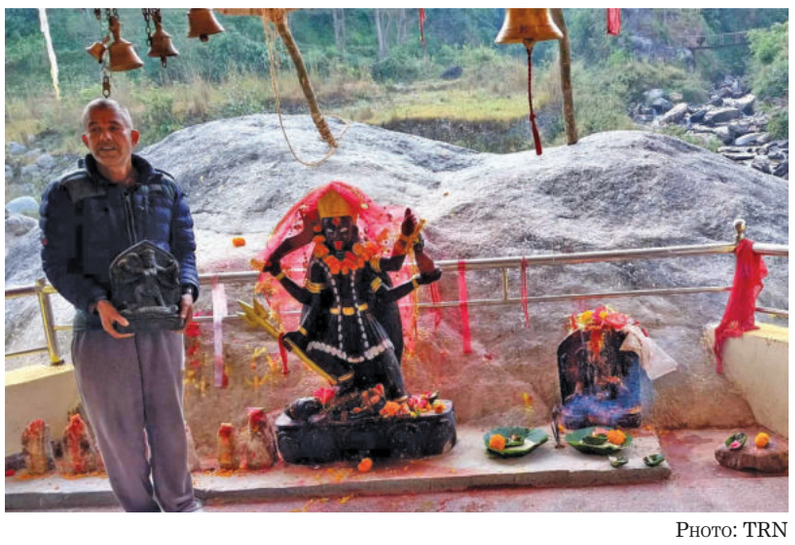


PHOTO: TRN
Priest showing Satchu of a god to demonstrate in Kalika fair at Namtar of Makwanpur.

According to him, devotees come to worship Kalika Devi with the belief that their wishes will be fulfilled. He said that those who have vowed to come to the temple on Dhanya Purnima visit it on that day and those who have not made such a vow visit the temple on Chandi Purnima.

ASIAN SHARES GAIN IN QUIET HOLIDAY TRADING

AP
Bangkok, Dec. 25

Asian shares were mostly higher on Monday after Wall Street capped its eighth straight winning week with a quiet finish following reports showing inflation on the way down and the economy potentially on the way up.

Tokyo's Nikkei 225 added 0.3% to 33,254.03 and the Shanghai Composite index edged 0.1% higher, to 2,918.93. The Taiex in Taiwan gained 0.1% and Bangkok's SET rose 0.1%.

Most markets in the region and beyond were closed for the Christmas holiday.

Chinese regulators announced approvals of more than 100 online games and issued a statement expressing support for the industry after draft guidelines issued Friday caused share prices of major games makers like Tencent and Netease to plunge.

On Friday, the S&P 500 rose 0.2% to sit less than 1% below its record set nearly two years ago, at 4,754.63.

Gandaki govt intensifies infrastructure development

RSS
Gandaki, Dec. 25

The Gandaki Province government has intensified the construction of physical infrastructures, including road and bridge. According to the Infrastructure Development Office, Baglung, lately the construction of newly-designed and old infrastructure projects was gradually gaining momentum.

Office Chief Dinesh Kumar Ghimire said the projects that were already contracted out and new projects have entered into implementation.

He mentioned that the office had returned the construction company to resume the works for problematic projects.

He informed that the work of old multi-year road project has progressed. He said that contracts for more than half projects worth Rs 3 million to Rs 20 million were signed.

The office has a total budget of Rs. 880 million for the current fiscal year. A total of 65 projects, both new and old, are scheduled to be implemented through the office. According to the office chief Ghimire, the detailed project reports of two roads and two road bridges to be constructed in the current fiscal year are being developed.

The progress of multi-year road and bridge construction was sluggish lately.

Ghimire said the contractor company that remained reluctant was taken back to work after the progress was stopped.

The contractor companies have readied for resuming stalled construction works after preparation for terminating the contractors and blacklisting the dysfunctional companies.

The office had placed six road projects as problematic.

The budget has been approved by the Ministry of Economic Affairs on the recommendation of the Ministry of Physical Affairs for the multi-year contract of two roads and two road bridges.

An additional Rs 210 million budget has been sought to complete the old multi-year schemes this year.

Bardibas Mayor joins locals to chase away wild elephants

BY RABINDRA UPRETI
Bardibas, Dec. 25



PHOTO: RABINDRA UPRETI/TRN
Bardibas Municipality Mayor Pralahad Chhetri along with local people and security forces are chasing away the wild elephants which were causing troubles to the locals.

Bardibas Municipality Mayor Pralahad Chhetri came out in the field to drive away the wild elephants which were causing troubles to the locals.

After a pair of elephants started frequenting the human settlements at night, destroying houses and crops, Mayor Chhetri has joined the locals to chase the animals.

In his initiative, a collaborative team consisting of District Coordination Committee Chief Suman Lal Karna, Superintendent of the Armed Police Force Lekhnath Khanal, Deputy Superintendent of Bardibas Area Police Bijay Yadav, Armed Forest Guards, Forest Staff, Ward chairs, and individuals affected by elephant berserks has begun searching for the elephants and chasing them from their hiding places.

The team has reached the forest areas near the East-West Railway track and Myakhare searching for the elephants and their hide.

The search operation started from the area, based on the information provided by the local herders, who said they saw the elephants in bushes near the railway track while they were in the jungle to collect grass.

These elephants hide in the forest during the day and enter the settlement after nightfall. However, the team has not been able to find the elephants.

But surprisingly, the elephants have stopped entering the settlement since the launching of the search operation.

Ward Chairmen Shyam Raja Singh and Shamsher Singh Lama said that the elephants entered different villages of Bardibas Municipality Ward No. 2 and Ward No. 8, destroyed the grain and vegetable crops planted in 18 bighas of land and pulled down the houses of 15 families.

Mayor Chhetri said that he tried to drive away the elephants in his initiative after the people suffered a lot from the elephants entering the municipality.

The 'search and chase away' campaign has been launched after they were left with no other option to control the elephant terror, Chhetri said.

According to him, "Because of the elephants, the people have not been able to sleep for two months, nor have they been able to grow crops."

In recent times, conflicts between the animals and humans have escalated in the northern part of Mahottari district when wildlife has been encroaching upon settlements in search of food.

The scarcity of forest cover, human encroachment, lack of water, and diminishing corridors have forced the elephants to enter human settlements, foresters said.

The ecology of wildlife has suffered due to the absence of development structures that are friendly to them. Presently, forests are being cleared for national pride projects such as transmission lines, roads, and railway tracks.

Division Forest Chief Santosh Jha said that these structures, constructed without prioritising wildlife concerns, have destroyed not only their habitats but have also impeded their natural movement.

IGP Kunwar opens new DPO building in Mugu

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Inspector General of Police (IGP) of Nepal Police Basanta Bahadur Kunwar inaugurated the newly constructed District Police Office and other units under it.

The IGP inaugurated the DPO and its barracks, the residences of the head of the office, and senior police officers, a detention cell and a kitchen built on the premises of the District Police Office Mugu at a special function organised in Mugu on Sunday.

According to a press statement issued by the Police Headquarters on Monday, following the inauguration, the IGP also inspected the constructed buildings.

On the occasion, IGP Kunwar presented letters of appreciation to various dignitaries who assisted in the construction work.

Following the inspection, IGP Kunwar said that the construction of new infrastructure boosts the morale of the police personnel and encourages the force to deliver quality services.

Inspector General Kunwar said that the police force has always been at the forefront of effective crime investigation, peace and security management, protection of human rights and disaster relief works and has succeeded in establishing itself as a reliable and trustworthy organisation of the citizens.

IGP Kunwar said that the Nepal Police Headquarters was always determined to strengthen and enable the organisation through the acquisition and use of scientific and technical equipment by making the organisation self-sufficient in terms of housing and physical infrastructure.

The IGP inaugurated the DPO and its barracks, the residences of the head of the office, and senior police officers, a detention cell and a kitchen built on the premises of the District Police Office Mugu at a special function organised in Mugu on Sunday.

Deputy Inspector General of Police (DIGP) Bhim Prasad Dhakal, Chief of Karnali Province Police Office, expressed his thanks for helping the organisation to materialise the dream of constructing a new building in the district.

On the occasion, Mugu's Chief District Officer Topendra Bahadur K.C. and Chief of Chhayanath Municipality Bishnu Kumar Bham were also present at the ceremony.

From the regular budget of the government of Nepal, the DPO building was constructed at Rs. 25.8 million and the police barracks, head of office/senior police officer residence, detention cells and kitchen were built spending Rs. 75.6 million.

Person with disability gets citizenship at doorstep



PHOTO: TRN
A physically and mentally challenged youth receiving citizenship certificate at his home in Makawanpur, Monday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Hetauda, Dec. 25

A physically and mentally challenged youth in Makawanpur has been able to receive his citizenship certificate in his home.

A team from the Makawanpur's District Administration Office (DAO) travelled to the home of Nir Bahadur Jimba, 17, in Bagmati Rural Municipality-7, on Saturday and gave him his citizenship certificate.

The DAO's Administrative Officer Saroj Paudel said that the team went to Jimba's home after receiving information about his condition and understanding that he would not be able to travel to the district headquarters Hetauda to apply for his citizenship.

Paudel informed that the team took the official register, collected Jimba's signature and fingerprint and pasted his photo on the form.

He told The Rising Nepal that the DAO started giving people with disabilities citizenships in their own homes after the officials once saw a person being forcibly and painfully brought to the administration to receive his certificate.

A man in Makawanpurgadhi Rural Municipality-5 was also able to receive his certificate in his home under this service.

Manang schools shifted to Kathmandu for winter

BY YADU PRASAD BHATTA
Manang, Dec. 25



PHOTO: YADU PRASAD BHATTA/TRN
One of the two schools shifted at Swyambhu premises in Kathmandu.

Extreme cold has forced the schools of Narpa Bhumi Rural Municipality to move to Kathmandu.

According to Konjo Tenzing Lama, chairman of the rural municipality, the Nar Basic School of Nar and Phu Basic School of Phu had moved to Kathmandu. He informed that the local level had arranged for the schools' 18 students to live in the capital and had coordinated with a school in Nagarjun to operate their classes.

The two schools moved to Kathmandu on Sunday. They will return to Narpa Bhumi for the new academic session after three and a half months. The government offices and police stations in Narpa Bhumi have already moved to the district headquarters to avoid the freezing chill.

The rural municipality has also established a temporary office at Koto, Chame Rural Municipality-3, to deliver services.

The residents have also moved to Lamjung, Kathmandu and Pokhara to evade the cold. This has made Narpa Bhumi empty.

Four devotees arrive in Larumba after 36 days' walk from Assam



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Damak, Dec. 25

Wishing for world peace, a team from Assam, India, has arrived in Mangsebung, a holy place of Kirat devotees in Ilam. The team concluded their walk by meeting religious leader Atmanand Lingden at Larumba in Mangsebung Rural Municipality. A grand programme was organised on Sunday at Niji Guru Ashram Darshanalaya located in Mangsebung- 5 to welcome the devotees.

Four persons, Suman Lohorung Rai, Panch Bahadur Rumdali Rai, Amit Kumar Saba and Santa Bahadur Bhiivak, started their religious pilgrimage from Lakhimpur district of Assam, India, on November 18.

The team entered Nepal from the Kakadbhitta border crossing and reached the religious tourist place of Larumba on Sunday through Jhapa. The team reached their final destination on the 36th day of their journey and were honoured by various organisations related to Kirant religion right from Kakadbhitta in Jhapa.

Kehersing Yonghang, President of Kirat Chotlung Muhingum Angsi Manggenna Seva, said that the team with pictures of religious leaders and Gurumothers, promoting Mangsebung, have been honoured. He said that it has greatly helped the development of religious tourism and faith in this region.

On that occasion, Kirant religious leader Atmanand Lingden welcomed and thanked the pilgrims for coming to the area and said that world peace would be possible if everyone showed their determination to it.

Religious Guru Atmanand Lingden moved to Larumba from Ibhang, a village near it, and has been living in Larumba of Mangsebung village since 1978. Larumba, since then, has been developed as a religious place.

Atmananda is the eldest son of Mahaguru Falgunanda's eldest brother. Nowadays, Larumba is also being developed as a place to study the religious texts of the Kirant community.

Larumba lies in a hill of Ilam, 25 km away from Damak, Jhapa.

TWO DIE WHEN BUS HITS MOTORCYCLE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Two persons were killed in a motorcycle accident in Sindhuli on Monday.

Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Chiranjeevi Dahal said that the two riders were killed when a bus with registration number 'Bagmati Province-01-006 B 4593' coming to Kathmandu from Manthali, Ramechhap, hit the motorcycle (Ba 60 P 3545) along the B.P. Highway at Bohoretar in Sunkoshi Rural Municipality-3, Sindhuli, at 8:30 am on Monday.

A bulletin of the Police Headquarters quoted DSP Dahal as saying that the motorcycle rider, 20-year-old Susan Rai of Halesi Tuwachung Municipality-2 of Khotang, and pillion rider 18-year-old Munakala Rai of Diktel Municipality-10, Khotang, died.

Police said that they have arrested bus driver Rupesh Adhikari, 24, of Manthali-13, Ramechhap.

Meanwhile, the angry locals set the bus on fire.

Dharan to mark Chasok festival for five days

BY NISHA RAI
Dharan, Dec. 25

Chasok Tangnam, the main festival of the Limbu community, is going to start in Dharan on Tuesday.

Organising a press meet on Monday, Tirtha Mademba, President of Kirant Yakthum Chumlung, informed that the festival would run for five days by organising various cultural programmes at Kirat Yakthung Chulung Him building.

He said that as described in the Mundhum of the Limbu Yakthungwa, Limbus eat the new crops only offering their first harvest to the god Yuma Mang, and the day is marked as Chasok festival.

In ancient times, the Chasok festival used to be celebrated by every household after harvesting the crops every year.

But after a decision of Kiyachu, the practice of marking the festival in groups has begun from Dharan since 1993/94, said Mademba.

Niranti Tumbape, the general secretary of Kirant Yakthum Chumlung, said that this year's Chasok Tangnam was also taken as a protest against the naming of Koshi Province.

Tumbape said, "Every year, we have been celebrating Chasok with joy, but this year we will celebrate it with all our hearts and minds as a protest against the naming of Koshi Province.

In ancient times, the Chasok festival used to be celebrated by every household after harvesting the crops every year.

District President Mohan Hukpa Chongbang said that the Chasok festival is celebrated not only in Nepal but also in foreign lands.

The festival will be held in Dharan for five days. The organisers said that on the first day, all the people of Limbuwan will perform one night Chamen Tangsing (ritual for prosperity, good health and harmony).

On the morning of the second day, Chasok Puja and Hadyukna Puja will be performed at Bijaypur by offering garlands to the statue of Tiengsi Sirijanga at Sirijanga Chowk.

On the third day, Kelang, Yalang and Palam will be organised and on the fourth day, Yakthung games like Li Apma (shooting), Paklum Lepma (ball throwing), Thakthakma (thread weaving) and Hakpare Samlo will be organised.

On the fifth day, a cultural exhibition of tribal organisations will be organised, said the organisers.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Three things cannot be long hidden: the sun, the moon, and the truth.
- Buddha

EDITORIAL

Bright Economic Outlook

Nepal's economy is finally showing signs of recovery. The internal and external sectors of the economy had taken crushing blows from COVID-19 pandemic followed by Russia-Ukraine war. But now, the economic indicators are moving in the positive direction. There have been improvements in financial and monetary sectors as well. Without economic reform at the policy level, procedure and institutional levels undertaken by the government, experts say, cannot materialise. The number foreign tourist arrival has returned to the pre-pandemic levels, and along with them, foreign currency reserves have seen an encouraging rise.

To make things better, inflation has also decreased. According to the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) data, consumer price inflation for the first four months of the current fiscal year stands at 5.38 per cent, down from 7.38 per cent in mid-December last year. The foreign exchange reserves increased by 10.2 per cent to Rs. 1696.78 billion in mid-November 2023 from Rs. 1530.36 billion in mid-July 2023. The remittance inflow increased by 26.4 per cent to 477.96 billion over that period. The current balance of payment is at a surplus of 147.11 billion.

In an effort to provide relief to the entrepreneurs, consumers, businesspersons, and industrialists, the government has taken steps to reduce the bank interest rate. The weighted average interbank transaction among the banks has come down to 3.47 per cent from 8.50 per cent during the period. The central bank has also lowered the bank rate from 7.5 per cent to 7 per cent and policy rate from 6.5 per cent to 5.5 per cent.

What's more, this past year, the government has taken significant decisions on infrastructure developments. The decision to go ahead with the construction of Budhigandaki and Karnali Chisapani Reservior-based hydropower projects is a testament to this fact. Similar commitment to build Upper Arun and Dudhkoshi hydropower projects has raised hope that the country will be able to export significantly more electricity in the coming days. With the rapid development of power sector, the installed hydropower capacity has reached 28,000 MW, enough to meet 94 per cent of the country's energy need.

During Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda's June visit to India, an agreement was signed to sell 10,000 MW of electricity to the southern immediate neighbour in 10 years as well as to finalise the detailed project report of the Pancheshwor multi-purpose project within three months, among others. Similarly, during PM's visit to China in September, both sides agreed to build a 'Trans-Himalayan Multi-Dimensional Connectivity Network' as well as to reopen Nepal-China checkpoints. There were also agreements to give final shape to 'Nepal-China Electric Power Co-operation Plan' in addition to initiate the activities of 200-kV Jilong-Kerung- Rasuwagadhi-Chilime Inter-state Transmission Line as soon as possible.

Likewise, the national pride project, Pokhara Regional International Airport, inaugurated on January 1, 2023 has made a significant contribution in air connectivity. The government is also gearing up to organise investment summit in Kathmandu from April 21, 2024. Amid brightening economic outlook, there have been complaints about the dearth of good jobs that pay enough to live a decent life. The country has also seen an export decline, with potential job losses in the sector. For example, palm oil worth Rs. 2.47 billion has been exported in the first five months of the current fiscal year, down from 10.87 billion during the same period last fiscal. Measures must be taken to reverse this trend.

COP28 Climate Funding

MITCHELL BLATT

Protecting individuals and communities from the severe consequences of climate change is expensive. As a result, finance was one of the most critical issues on the agenda at the United Nations COP28 climate summit.

In 2009, parties at the Copenhagen climate summit agreed that developed countries must provide the developing world with $100 billion annually to cut greenhouse gas emissions and manage the impacts of climate change by 2020. It wasn't until 2023 that wealthy nations met their pledge of providing $100 billion to those in need.

Last year, at COP27 in Sharm El Sheikh, a coastal city in southern Egypt, participants agreed to establish the first fund dedicated to this purpose. The wealthiest countries were "urged" to contribute, while middle-income countries with emerging economies were "encouraged" to do so. Now, the focus should shift to locking in and increasing the fund's resources to compensate for losses and damages.

There was progress in securing these contributions at COP28. Germany and the United Arab Emirates each contributed $100 million, the European Union added $145 million, and the United Kingdom contributed $75 million. However, the United States pledged only $17.5 million. Since previous pledges haven't always matched what was promised, even $17 million is not guaranteed.

Even with existing contributions, the fund will likely fall short of covering the exorbitant costs expected to be borne by developing countries due to climate change. According to a report by the U.S. Global Leadership Council, extreme weather already causes $520 billion in economic losses annually, disproportionately affecting the developing world. These losses are set to grow as natural disasters become more frequent and severe, pushing an estimated 26 million people annually into poverty – a figure expected to rise.

We've known for decades that natural disasters are getting worse, but we haven't done enough about it. As early as 2005, American researchers found that the frequency of Category 4 and 5 hurricanes had doubled in the previous 30 years. The findings were publicized in a publication by the U.S. National Science Foundation. Despite substantial research by American scientists, the U.S. government has been reluctant to take action.

Former Republican presidents, such as George W. Bush and Donald Trump, have downplayed and sometimes even denied the severity of climate change. In contrast, Democratic presidents, like Barack Obama and Joe Biden, speak seriously about the issue, but their actions pale in comparison to those of many foreign leaders. Biden skipped COP28 this year, stating he would continue to "tackle the climate crisis" from Washington, D.C.

However, the Biden administration has been attempting to limit the scope of the loss and damage fund. Administration officials have argued that the fund should be limited to only those countries designated as "most vulnerable." The U.S., with the highest carbon emissions per capita, contributed less to the fund than most other developed countries.

That was not the only controversy at COP28. The actions by fossil fuel companies to try to greenwash their responsibility for climate change were also scrutinised. Despite these points of contention, progress is being made in slowing the rate of climate change. Ten years ago, it was estimated that the average global temperature would rise by 4 degrees Celsius by the end of the 21st century. Now, the temperature is only expected to rise by 2.5 degrees because of the actions almost every country has taken. It's still above the 2-degree limit the world is supposed to target, but sustained efforts could yield further progress.

- China.org.cn

Maintain Religious Tolerance



Narayan Upadhyay

The constitution of our country protects religious freedom, stating that every individual is free to practice any religion s/he desire. However, the constitution also states that no one has the authority to insult another person's faith while practicing their own. Our constitution includes clauses (Articles 26 and 4) that aim at promoting and protecting religious harmony, peace and goodwill in our nation which is rich in its cultural diversity. Lately, many people, mostly Hindus, have claimed that the Minister for Tourism, Civil Aviation, and Culture, Sudan Kirati, has violated these constitutionally protected clauses when he spoke favourably of Christianity at a ceremony last week. Minister Kirati declared at a function in the capital that Christianity is guaranteed by the constitution and that anyone who does not accept this fact is a 'traitor'.

"If anyone is found violating this constitution clause, they are traitors, and for committing such a crime, we should handcuff them and put them behind bars," said the Minister whose 'controversial' statement quickly went viral on social media, and many people criticised him for being anti-constitutional and disrespectful to Hindus. His statement drew the ire of none other than Rabi Lamichhane, chairperson of the Rastriya Swatantra Party, who wrote that Kirati's statement had disturbed social harmony and religious tolerance and was inflammatory and irresponsible that violated official dignity. RPP Nepal leader Kamal Thapa urged for Kirati's dismissal for calling 'all non-Christians traitors.'

Religious freedom

In our country, everyone has the right to follow their faith in whichever way they see fit. A person is also free not to follow any religion if he or she so chooses. In a secular state, neither the government nor the state may favour any particular religion. People cannot also speak ill of others' faith while adhering to their own. Many commentators believe Minister Kirati has violated the constitution in this case by undermining the ethos of secularism while publicly endorsing Christianity. After his statement sparked outrage, Minister Kirati attempted to justify himself, claiming that his statement on religious freedom and equality was exaggerated and he urged everyone to read his entire speech in which he discussed minorities' constitutional rights.

Following the minister's statement, many Hindus have expressed their displeasure with him, citing he has offended their religious sensitivities by labeling "all non-Christians" traitors. In a country where Hindus constitute the majority, how can the Minister of Culture publicly support Christianity? They claimed that the Minister had been careless in his job as Minister of Culture because popular Hindu shrines in the country, such as Pashupatinath and others, come under his direct supervision. Meanwhile, proponents of democratic ideals and principles argue that in democracies, political parties, leaders, and ministers have an obligation to protect and advance the interests of the majority of people rather than hurting the sentiments of these people.

> In a secular state, neither the government nor the state may favour any particular religion. People cannot also speak ill of others' faith while adhering to their own.

Many hardened Hindus, meanwhile, see Minister Kirati's statement in another light. They accuse some leaders of helping increase in the number of Christians and churches in Nepal. They argue that the conversion of poor Hindus to Christianity with the promise of cash and other generosity is primarily responsible for the increase in the number of Christians in Nepal in recent years. The rate of conversion would have been higher, if the constitution had not forbidden both forceful and the employment of other means for religious conversion. In Nepal, Christian missionary groups and individuals are accused of attracting destitute, illiterate Nepalis from rural and suburban areas and promising them financial and other assistance in order to proselytize them.

According to some commentators, Kirati's party, the CPN-Maoist Centre, which presently leads the government, may find it difficult to defend Kirati as a result of his statement. It may produce electoral repercussions for the party while also infuriating coalition allies who rely heavily on Hindu voters. Since entering mainstream politics and winning a landslide in 2008, the Maoist Centre has been losing support in successive polls. Many political experts believe that by inciting anti-Hindu feelings, Minister Kirati has gravely hurt his own party's chances in the upcoming election. The Maoist Centre that managed to bag only 32 seats in the last general election held in 2022 would likely encounter heavy opposition from Hindu voters in the general election in 2027.

Damage control

Hindu organisations and believers blame the erstwhile rebels for the country's growing Christian population. They also hold the former rebels responsible for removing the Hindu king and transforming the country into a secular state and republic. Kirati's uncalled-for statement sparked outrage, and his party will need to act quickly to contain the damage. Alternatively, the party could choose not to take action against the Minister, who has otherwise acquired popularity by making admirable decisions after assuming his office a year ago. However, his most recent remarks, which, many of his own party men think, he should not have made as a responsible minister, have brought him more flak, putting his ministerial job at risk.

Finally, it should be noted that any religious issue is highly sensitive in a diverse and multicultural country like ours and can elicit strong reactions from people if they feel offended by behaviours or remarks that contradict their religious beliefs. No one should try to incite anti-religious sentiment in a society. And when individuals belong to a position of prominence, the obligation to maintain religious and social harmony, peace and goodwill must become their priority.

(Upadhyay is former managing editor of this daily)

Boost Kathmandu-beautifying Campaign



Uttam Maharjan

When he became Mayor of the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) in 2022, Balendra Shah vowed to make Kathmandu one of the world's most beautiful and excellent cities. The Kathmandu-beautifying campaign was then set in motion. In fact, such a campaign was also initiated by ex-Mayor Bidya Sundar Shakya during his mayorship, when broomers were procured and used on the Kathmandu roads. Shakya thought that using broomers on the roads would make Kathmandu a dust-free city, which was his illusion. Although the broomers showed some positive results on the major roads which were already 'clean', their outcomes on the inner roads were like water off a duck's back. So the campaign miserably failed, leaving the capital as it was.

Dust-free city

The Balen city administration announced in June a similar campaign of making Kathmandu a dust-free city. A budget allocation of Rs. one billion has been earmarked for the campaign. Further, budget allocations have been made for the construction and improvement of public infrastructure (Rs. 7.34 billion), for solid waste management (Rs. 70 million), for the Metropolis Pride Project (Rs. 3.8 billion) focusing on ten thematic areas, for 25 thematic sector schemes under the Metropolis Golden Project (Rs. 2 billion) and for projects prioritised by 32 wards of the KMC (Rs. 1.76 billion). These projects are geared up towards beautifying the KMC.

The KMC has deployed an additional 300 cleaning staff to collect garbage at public places, including roadside and riverside areas. Additionally, 100 cleaning staff have been deployed under the Prime Minister Employment Programme to clear dust and weeds from pavements and walkways. The Prime Minister Employment Programme was initiated in 2019. The KMC has taken the initiative in segregating waste into biodegradable and non-biodegradable waste at the waste transfer station at Teku. In the past, households were also requested to do the segregation. But it has not been effective at the household level. Had all the households done the segregation, it would have been much easier for the KMC to manage waste.

However, the segregation is being done at Teku and the biodegradable waste is sent to the Sisdole landfill site for dumping. Some biodegradable waste is used in the bio-methanation plant provided by the European Union to generate power. When Balendra Shah assumed office as the KMC's Mayor, there was difficulty dumping waste into the Siddole dumping site owing to the protests by the locals of Sisdole and its surrounding areas. Now, there is no such difficulty and the waste-dumping work is proceeding smoothly.

The KMC has placed 4,000 dustbins at various public places. People can throw cigarette butts, plastic or paper covers and other refuse into the dustbins. The KMC has also built a shelter for stray cows and buffaloes in the Dakshinkali. The shelter has a capacity for housing 100 animals. Similarly, the KMC has built a shelter for stray dogs. A large number of dogs have been sterilised and anti-rabies vaccines have been administered on as many as 12,000 dogs in the KMC. It may be noted that managing stray dogs and cows as well as beggars is one of the important steps towards beautifying the capital city. However, managing beggars in the KMC has been a fiasco.

> There is a tendency to build roads by leaving both of their sides unpitched. These sides gather dust and make the roads dusty.

The KMC has also renovated some traffic islands and decorated them with green plants and colourful flowers. Some bridges have been decorated with lights. Some footpaths have been repaired and paved. Dangling wires giving an ugly look to the city have been managed. However, such wires are yet to be managed in some places. Footpath vendors have been removed in some places. But, it has not been fully successful. The KMC has initiated the campaign with a good intention, but there are hurdles galore. Plants are planted haphazardly along footpaths. Construction and other materials are scattered on the roads. Vehicles are haphazardly parks on the roads. There are traffic snarl-ups in the city. Traffic lights are not properly working in many places.

Despite the campaign, the dream of making Kathmandu a dust-free city seems to be far-fetched. Just cleaning the roads even every day will not make the city dust-free. The city will definitely be cleaner but not dust-free. For this, sources of dust and other refuse need to be eliminated by building proper infrastructure. There is a tendency to build roads by leaving both of their sides unpitched. These sides gather dust and make the roads dusty. On the other hand, street vendors, roadside shopkeepers and pedestrians tend to litter the roads or streets.

There should be a strict provision against those who litter the roads or streets. The street vendors should clean up before leaving the places of vending, whereas the shopkeepers should clean up just before closing their shops. And the pedestrians should not litter the roads or streets. Moreover, there should be an anti-spitting campaign. Those who spit on the roads or streets should be penalised. But there should be receptacles along the roads or streets for spitting purposes.

Coordination

Digging the roads or streets seems to be perennial in the KMC. Now, the underground cabling works of the Nepal Electricity Authority are going on. Digging works for other purposes such as laying water or drainage pipes or repairing them seem to be an everyday affair. Such works should be conducted in coordination with various government units. But there does not seem to be any coordination. After the roads or streets are dug, they are not properly filled in and pitched, which gives rise to dust pollution.

In fact, making Kathmandu a clean city is a formidable challenge. The KMC needs to pay attention to many aspects. Public toilets are not adequate in the city. The number of toilets should be increased. Air pollution is another problem that must be tackled. Although petrol and diesel vehicles are largely responsible for causing air pollution, their imports are increasing. However, electric vehicles are growing in popularity in recent times. The replacement of vehicles running on fossil fuel should be supplanted by electric vehicles to reduce air pollution. But it takes time. However, it behoves the KMC to build necessary infrastructure to eliminate dust from the roads or streets and fill in and pitch the roads or streets after they have been dug so that the city can be made dust-free.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 26, 1973

Opinion Poll In Canada On ME

Montreal, Dec 25: Three out of four Canadians refuse to take side in the Middle East conflict, according to an opinion poll made public here today, says AFP.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Turn Bhaktapur Into A Green City



A picture, published on page 6 in this daily on Dec 21, shows a mirror to the face of Bhaktapur, where vehicles still move freely in the world-famous heritage site of Nyatapola precincts. Balen has banned vehicle movements in Hanuman Dhoka, and the mayor of Bhaktapur must do so to maintain the sanctity of the heritage sites.

The Bhaktapur mayor can go further and ban all fossil fuel vehicles, including two-wheelers, in the city, from the cancer hospital in the west to Kamal Binayak in the east and Indrayeni in the north to Hanuman Ghat in the south. We can learn from the London mayor's Ulez (Ultra Low Emission Zone) to regulate vehicles and control pollution in conch-shell-shaped Bhaktapur.

We must showcase Bhaktapur as the greenest city in Southeast Asia if not the whole world. It takes me only about two hours to take a perambulation around Bhaktapur; I used to do briskly in an hour a decade ago.

It does not tax ones' brain too much to turn Bhaktapur into a zero-emission heritage city for tourists to savour.

Manohar Shrestha
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A father was at the beach with his children when the four-year-old son ran up to him, grabbed his hand, and led him to the shore, where a seagull lay dead in the sand.

"Daddy, what happened to him?" the son asked.

"He died and went to Heaven," the dad replied.

The boy thought a moment and then said, "Did God throw him back down?"

+++++

A blonde was sitting on the train reading the newspaper. The headline shouted, "12 Brazillian Soldiers Killed."

She shook her head at the sad news, then she turned to the stranger sitting next to her and asked, "How many is a Brazillian?"

Egypt floats plan to end Israel-Hamas war



PHOTO: AP

Israeli soldiers carry the flag-draped casket of Staff Sgt. Birhanu Kassie during his funeral at Mt. Herzl military cemetery in Jerusalem, Sunday, Dec. 24, 2023.

AP
Cairo, Dec. 25

Egypt has put forward an ambitious, initial proposal to end the Israel-Hamas war with a cease-fire, a phased hostage release and the creation of a Palestinian government of experts who would administer the Gaza Strip and occupied West Bank, a senior Egyptian official and a European diplomat said Monday.

The proposal, worked out with the Gulf nation of Qatar, has been presented to Israel, Hamas, the United States and European governments but still appeared preliminary. It falls short of Israel's professed goal of outright crushing Hamas and would appear not to meet Israel's insistence on keeping military control over Gaza for an extended period after the war.

Israel's War Cabinet, including Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, will meet later Monday discuss the hostage situation, among other topics, an Israeli official said, but would not say if they would discuss the Egyptian proposal. The official spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to talk to the media.

Word of the proposal comes after three bloody days across Gaza before Christmas Day in which Israeli airstrikes killed dozens of Palestinians at a time and 17 troops were killed in ground fighting in the north, center and south of the territory.

The war has devastated large parts of Gaza, killed more than 20,400 Palestinians and displaced almost all of the territory's 2.3 million people.

The mounting death toll among Israeli troops — 156 since the ground offensive began — could erode public support for the war, which was sparked when Hamas-led militants stormed communities in southern Israel on Oct. 7, killing 1,200 and taking 240 hostage.

Israelis still largely stand behind the country's stated goals of crushing Hamas' governing and military capabilities and releasing the remaining 129 captives. That's despite rising international pressure against Israel's offensive, and the soaring death toll and unprecedented suffering among Palestinians.

The Egyptian proposal was an ambitious bid not only to end the war but also to lay out a plan for the day after.

It calls for an initial cease-fire of up to two weeks during which Palestinian militants would free 40 to 50 hostages, among them women, the sick and the elderly, in return for the release of 120-150 Palestinians from Israeli prisons, the Egyptian official said. He spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the ongoing talks.

At the same time, negotiations would continue on extending the cease-fire and the release of more hostages and bodies held by Palestinian militants, he said.

Egypt and Qatar would also work with all Palestinian factions, including Hamas, to agree on the establishment of a government of experts, he said. The government would rule Gaza and the West Bank for a transitional period as Palestinian factions settle their disputes and agree on a roadmap to hold presidential and parliamentary elections, he added.

West Bank prays for peace in Gaza



PHOTO: AFP

Israel has vowed to press on with its Gaza military campaign.

AFP
Zababdeh, Dec. 25

An unusual silence fell over the streets of Zababdeh, a Palestinian village that is home to one of the biggest Christian communities in the occupied West Bank.

On any other Christmas Day, Palestinian Christians would have flocked from surrounding towns to enjoy the fairy lights and a festive market in the village of some 5,000 people.

But as the war rages in Gaza and violence also surges in the West Bank, the Christian community here is in no mood to celebrate Christmas on Monday.

This year its members are praying for peace and mourning the dead, worried too about violence even closer to home.

Early on Christmas Day, AFP journalists heard gunfire and sirens in nearby Jenin, the city that has seen near daily raids by Israeli forces.

"How can we celebrate?" said Nazeria Yousef Deabis, 76, who has lived in Zababdeh all her life and never known the atmosphere so sombre.

There is no Christmas tree in her house.

"People don't feel festive -- they've lost friends and relatives in Gaza," she said. "The occupation (Israel) is destroying Jenin and children are being brutally killed."

The Israeli army says its frequent raids in Jenin, especially on the adjacent refugee camp, target "terrorists", but the Palestinian health ministry in Ramallah says many of the dead are civilians.

Israeli forces and settlers have killed more than 300 people in the West Bank since the start of the war, Palestinian health officials say.

Israel has occupied the West Bank since the Six-Day war of 1967.

The war broke out when Hamas fighters attacked southern Israel on October 7 and killed about 1,140 people, mostly civilians, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

Israel's ensuing military campaign has killed at least 20,424 people, mostly women and children, according to Gaza's health ministry.

Plane stuck in France leaves for India

AP
France, Dec. 25

A charter plane grounded in France for a human trafficking investigation is scheduled to leave Monday for India, after an exceptional holiday ordeal that left some 300 Indians en route for Central America blocked inside a rural French airport for four days. A lawyer for the airline says most of the passengers will be aboard.

French authorities are still investigating the aim of the original flight, en route from the United Arab Emirates to Nicaragua, and two passengers have been detained. Prosecutors wouldn't comment on what kind of human trafficking was alleged, or whether the passengers' ultimate destination could have been the U.S., which has seen a surge in Indians crossing the Mexico-U.S. border this year.

French authorities worked through Christmas Eve and Christmas morning on formalities to allow passengers to leave the Vatry airfield in Champagne country, regional prosecutor Annick Browne told The Associated Press. The passengers include a 21-month-old child and 11 unaccompanied minors who were put under special administrative care.

The Legend Airlines A340 plane stopped Thursday for refueling in Vatry en route from Fujairah airport for Managua, Nicaragua, and was grounded by police based on an anonymous tip that it could be carrying trafficking victims.

The airport was requisitioned by police for days, and then turned into a makeshift courtroom Sunday as judges, lawyers and interpreters filled the terminal to carry out emergency hearings to determine next steps.

The plane received permission Sunday to leave France and was expected to depart Monday, according to an official with the Marne regional administration. A passenger stairwell was in place Monday morning beneath the unmarked plane, which has been waiting on the tarmac since Thursday.

Legend Airlines lawyer Liliana Bakayoko said it received approval from French authorities to transport 301 of the 303 passengers on a direct flight Monday to Mumbai, but that the final figure is expected to be lower.

Several passengers have requested asylum in France, according to an official with the Marne regional prefecture.

Bakayoko said some other passengers don't want to go to India because they paid for a tourism trip to Nicaragua. The airline has denied any role in possible human trafficking.

Lawyers at Sunday's hearings protested authorities' overall handling of the strange situation and the passengers' rights.

Foreigners can be held up to four days in a transit zone for police investigations in France, after which a special judge must rule on whether to extend that for eight days. Local officials, medics and volunteers installed cots and ensured regular meals and showers for those held in the Vatry airport.

The U.S. government has designated Nicaragua as one of several countries deemed as failing to meet minimum standards for eliminating human trafficking.

Israel continues Gaza airstrikes, no end in sight

AFP
Gaza Strip, Dec. 25



Israel pounded Gaza on Monday, exacerbating the dire conditions for civilians with no end in sight to the war Hamas says has killed more than 20,000 people in the Palestinian territory.

Christmas festivities in Bethlehem, the revered birthplace of Jesus Christ in the occupied West Bank, were effectively scrapped amid the conflict, leaving the usually vibrant streets with only a handful of worshippers and tourists.

The war erupted when Hamas militants broke through Gaza's militarised border and attacked southern Israeli communities on October 7, killing about 1,140 people, mostly civilians, and seizing 250 hostages, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

Israel vowed to crush Hamas and launched a retaliatory military campaign in Gaza, including extensive aerial bombardment, that has killed at least 20,424 people, mostly women and children, according to the Hamas-run Palestinian territory's health ministry.

The Gaza health ministry said an Israeli air strike killed at least 70 people on Christmas Eve at the Al-Maghazi refugee camp.

The army said it was "reviewing the incident", adding it was "committed to international law including taking feasible steps to minimise harm to civilians".

Ten members of one family were killed in an Israeli strike on their house in the Jabalia camp in northern Gaza, the health ministry said.

In a separate attack, the ministry said 18 people were killed in an overnight strike on Khan Yunis.

There was no respite Christmas Day, with the army saying it continued its ground, air and sea operations and struck several Hamas targets, including commanders.

Before dawn, an Israeli strike "targeting a house" in the central Al-Zuwaida area of Gaza killed at least 12 people, mostly women and children, the health ministry said. AFP was unable to independently verify the tolls.

In southern Gaza, an AFP correspondent reported heavy bombings through the night in Rafah and Khan Yunis. In the north, live AFPTV footage on Monday morning showed a long plume of smoke extending across the horizon.

Grasping empty containers, dozens of Gazans waited on a street in Rafah for food to be distributed.

"We're fed up; this is not a life. I swear such a war has never happened before," said one of them, Nour Ismail. "Now there is real hunger. My children are dying of hunger."

Vast areas of Gaza lie in ruins and its 2.4 million people have endured dire shortages of water, food, fuel and medicine, alleviated only by the limited arrival of aid trucks. The head of the UN refugee agency, Filippo Grandi, called for an end to the suffering.

"A humanitarian ceasefire in Gaza is the only way forward," he wrote on X. "War defies logic and humanity, and prepares a future of more hatred and less peace."

World Health Organization chief Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus also renewed calls for a ceasefire, saying: "The decimation of the Gaza health system is a tragedy."

PRISM

Firefighters rescue deer

Maryland: Firefighters in Maryland came to the rescue of a deer that tried to vault into a yard and ended up trapped between a wooden fence and a wire fence.

The Prince George's County Fire/EMS Department said in a Facebook post that a crew from Chapel Oaks Station 838 was dispatched to a home in Cheverly where a deer became trapped between two fences.

"Using ingenuity and hand tools, firefighters quickly cut through a wire fence and rescued the deer," the post said.

The firefighters consulted with a local wildlife agency and determined the deer was not seriously injured and could be returned to the wild.

USDA clears Santa's reindeer

United States: Santa Claus won't have to worry about running afoul of the law for flying his reindeer into the United States after the animals were given clearance by the U.S. Department of Agriculture.

The USDA said its Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service issued a transit permit Thursday "to Mr. S. Nicholas Claus of the North Pole, a distributor with Gifts and Good Cheer, Inc."

The department said the permit will allow Santa's sleigh-pulling reindeer free passage in and out of the country between the hours of 6 p.m. Dec. 24 and 6 a.m. on Dec. 25.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1805 – Austria and France sign the Treaty of Pressburg.
1825 – Advocates of liberalism in Russia rise up against Czar Nicholas I in the Decembrist revolt, but are later suppressed.
1941 – U.S. President Franklin D. Roosevelt signs a bill establishing the fourth Thursday in November as Thanksgiving Day in the United States.
1941 – British Prime Minister Winston Churchill addresses a joint meeting of the U.S. Congress.
1998 – Iraq announces its intention to fire upon U.S. and British warplanes that patrol the northern and southern no-fly zones.
2006 – Two earthquakes in Hengchun, Taiwan measuring 7.0 and 6.9 on the Richter scale kill two and disrupt telecommunications across Asia.
2012 – China opens the world's longest high-speed rail route, which links Beijing and Guangzhou.

Afghan schoolgirls are finishing sixth grade in tears

AP
Afghanistan, Dec. 25



PHOTO: AP

Afghan girls attend a religious school, which remained open since the last year's Taliban takeover, in Kabul, Afghanistan, on Aug. 11, 2022.

Bahara Rustam, 13, took her last class at Bibi Razia School in Kabul on Dec. 11 knowing it was the end of her education. Under Taliban rule, she is unlikely to step foot in a classroom again.

In September 2021, a month after U.S. and NATO troops withdrew from Afghanistan following two decades of war, the Taliban announced that girls were barred from studying beyond sixth grade.

They extended this education ban to universities in December 2022.

The Taliban have defied global condemnation and warnings that the restrictions will make it almost impossible for them to gain recognition as the country's legitimate rulers.

Last week, U.N. special envoy Roza Otunbayeva expressed concern that a generation of Afghan girls is falling behind with each day that passes.

Last week, an official in the Education Ministry said Afghan girls of all ages are allowed to study in religious schools known as madrassas, which have traditionally been boys-only.

But Otunbayeva said it was unclear if there was a standardized curriculum that allowed modern subjects.

Bahara is holding onto her education and pores over textbooks at home. "Graduating (from sixth grade) means we are going to seventh grade," she said. "But all of our classmates cried and we were very disappointed."

There was no graduation ceremony for the girls at Bibi Razia School.

In another part of Kabul, 13-year old Setayesh Sahibzada wonders what the future holds for her. She is sad she can't go to school anymore to achieve her dreams.

"I can't stand on my own two feet," she said. "I wanted to be a teacher.

But now I can't study, I can't go to school."

Analyst Muhammad Saleem Paigir warned that excluding women and girls from education will be disastrous for Afghanistan.

"We understand that illiterate people can never be free and prosperous," he said.

The Taliban have barred women from many public spaces and most jobs, all but confining women to their homes.

BUTWAL-NARAYANGADH ROAD EXPANSION NOT GAINING PACE

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gaindakot, Dec. 25

The Butwal-Narayangadh road section, which has been under construction as part of the National Pride Project for the past five years, has faced criticism for its slow progress.

To exert pressure to expedite the project and complete it swiftly, Rastriya Swotantra Party (RSP) has initiated a pressure campaign starting on Monday.

Rabi Lamichhane, the chairman of the party, said that the RSP has started a walk to draw the attention of both the government and the contractors to speed up the work of expanding the Narayangadh-Butwal road section of East Nawalparasi.

Lamichhane led the walk which started from Bhrikuti Chowk of the Gaidakot Municipality-2 at 10am. Lamichhane said that although this road is a project of national pride, it is unfortunate that the work has not picked up the speed.



PHOTO: RSS

A woman harvesting strawberries at a strawberry farm in Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City of Dang district.

Travel agent held on fake visit visa scam

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Police have arrested a travel agency operator on a charge of sending people overseas by producing fake documents.

The Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office detained 45-year-old Binod Karki, the owner of City Tours and Travels of Mahalakshmi Municipality-4 Imadol of Lalitpur on December 21 from Balkhu. Police have, however, confirmed his arrest after police collected details against him.

Superintendent of Police (SP) and Spokesperson for the Crime Investigation Office Rabindra Regmi said that Karki, who is also a leader of the Nepali Congress, was arrested after his involvement was proven. He is a permanent resident of Patharisanischare Municipality-7 in Morang district.

In the Provincial Assembly member election held in November 2022, Karki was defeated by CPN-UM's candidate Lilaballav Adhikari from Morang-2.

According to SP Regmi, Karki had been assisting in human trafficking by sending them abroad on visit visas based on fake documents.

SP Karki said that he was taken to the Kathmandu Police Range, the district police office, for further investigation.

The Security Office of Tribhuvan International Airport had seized 1,513 passports from last September with suspicious documents of young men and women going abroad on visit visas.

Similarly, the police have seized 246 documents which contain fake academic certificates of grade 12. Likewise, work permits, proof of relationship, police reports and bank statements were also found to be fake.

In the case, police have already arrested some government employees of the Department of Immigration, Nepal Airlines and operators of tours and travel agencies.

Over 46% loan shark cases solved in Madhes

BY DHIRENDRA PRASAD SAH
Dhanusha, Dec. 25

Nilam Devi, who was tormented by loan sharks for six years, is feeling relieved after she became debt-free. Nilam's Rs. 100,000 debt was settled in mutual understanding after the Commission formed to resolve unfair transactions (loan-sharking) began to work in the district.

The money she borrowed reached Rs. 350,000 including the principal and interest, as 3 per cent per month interest was levied on her. Nilam, a daily wage earner, was continuously paying the interest but she could not pay the capital amount as the interest was very high.

When the government initiated the process of investigation based on the complaints filed by unfair transactions, the government looked serious about the problem of loan shark victims like Nilam.

Similarly, Sunita Devi Malah, a resident of Tikathi, had taken a loan of Rs. 100,000 from Mahabir Prasad Shardas, a resident of Hanuman Nagar Kankalini Municipality-9 of the district, seven years ago on March 5, 2017.

A Tamasuk of Rs. 300,000 was signed when she took the loan of Rs. 100,000. When the loan's interest started piling up, Malah became restless. In the meantime, the Commission requested an application from the loan shark victims.

Road to Justice

On May 26, 2023, Malah registered the application at the Help Desk Branch of the Commission at the District Administration Office. The staff of that branch called the loan shark and started the discussion. After many discussions and prolonged efforts, an agreement was reached to settle it by paying Rs. 133,000. Both are happy now.

Status of application registration

Many complaints related to loan sharking have been registered in Madhes Province. In eight districts of the province, 22,967 applications were registered until the Commission's head office in Dhanusha closed on September 17, 2023. The total population of Madhes province is 6,126,288. It is confirmed that 0.37 per cent of the population in Madhes Province is tormented by loan sharks.

Most applications have been registered in Siraha district within the period specified by the Commission. A total of 3,788 applications have been registered in Siraha district. Similarly, the least number of applications were registered in Parsa with 1,875 complaints.

According to Assistant Chief District Officer Shiva Ram Gelal, the second largest complaints were registered in Dhanusha at 3,615 while 3,413 complaints were registered in Mahottari district.

Situation of discussion

The Commission has given priority to finalising the file of the registered complaints after the term of the Commission ended. The District Administration Office is trying to reach a consensus and settle the cases through mutual discussion. So far, a total of 8,762 files (applications) have been brought under discussion. Based on the number of applications registered, 38.15 per cent of files were discussed. According to the district-wise record, a maximum of 1,596 applications have been discussed between the victims and the perpetrators in the Bara district.

Reconciliation, settlement

After the discussion, 4,081 complaints have been resolved by forging mutual understanding. Based on the total number discussed, 46.57 per cent of the files (applications) have been settled through reconciliation. Based on the total registered applications, only 17.76 per cent have been cleared. Among the districts of Madhes Province, the maximum number of 684 petitions have been settled in Dhanusha. The lowest petitions with 238 complaints have been registered in Saptari. Likewise, 654 applications in Bara, 623 in Sarlahi, 552 in Mahottari, 459 in Parsa, 450 in Rautahat and 373 in Siraha have been resolved through reconciliation.

Similarly, the Commission has returned 166 Bighas, 19 Katthas, 18 Dhurs lands to the respective victims.

Over 16,000 applications under review

According to the data, in Madhes Province still, 16,799 applications are yet to be discussed. Preliminary discussions have not begun in 73.14 per cent of the total registered applications.

As per the district-wise details, the highest number (of 3,415) complaints have not been brought for discussion in Siraha. Similarly, 1,415 files are pending in Rautahat, 1991 in Saptari, 1,736 in Bara, 1,695 in Sarlahi, and 1,416 in Parsa.

Ukraine says it shot down Russian fighter jets and drones

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Dec. 25

Ukraine's air force on Monday reported that it shot down two Russian fighter jets during the night along with two cruise missiles and 28 Shahed-type drones.

The report said the attacks were aimed at southern and central regions of Ukraine, but that no casualties were immediately known. It said that 31 drones were launched in all, but details of what the three that weren't intercepted may have struck weren't given.

A summary from the Ukrainian presidential office said that one civilian was killed and at least four wounded in Russian attacks over the previous 24 hours. The death occurred in the town of Chornobaivka in the Kherson region, which is partly under Russian control and experiences daily fighting.

Ukraine observed Christmas on Monday, the first time the country has officially marked the holiday on Dec. 25 rather than the Jan. 7 date followed by some Orthodox countries, including Russia.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy signed legislation in July to move the public holiday's date. Ukraine is predominantly Orthodox Christian, but the faith is divided between two churches, one of which had long affiliation with the Russian Orthodox Church.

The Orthodox Church of Ukraine, which didn't recognize the authority of the Russian church and had been regarded as schismatic, was granted full recognition in 2018 by the Ecumenical Patriarch of Constantinople, Orthodoxy's top authority.

The Ukrainian Orthodox Church, which was a branch of the Russian church, announced in 2022 after the start of the Russia-Ukraine war that it was breaking ties with Moscow and considered itself autonomous.

PM to address the nation...

year since he assumed the office, the PM's Secretariat informed.

Although earlier Prachanda led two governments, he was unable to complete a year in office on both occasions. But this time, he is completing a year on Wednesday.

Puspa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, the Chairman of CPN (Maoist Centre), was appointed as the Prime Minister on December 25, 2022. Earlier, he had served as Prime Minister in 2008-9 and again in 2016-17. Speaking at a programme on December 22, Prime Minister Prachanda said that he would talk about the progress of the government during his address.

He had also expressed his commitment to addressing the nation on December 26 prioritising people's concerns starting from December 27.

He further said that he would call the ministers at Singha Durbar to closely examine their works.

He also expressed his intention to reshuffle the cabinet, removing some ministers who have not performed up to satisfactory standards.

Smooth supply of...

has been transferred to the ministries looking after the provincial agriculture sector to provide relief to the affected farmers. For the first time, the draft of the Agriculture Act has been prepared and the process has been taken forward to promote the interests of the agricultural produce and farmers.

A draft of the Right to Food and Food Sovereignty Regulations has also been prepared.

Foreign technical support

To reform the livestock sector, 15 Murrah buffalo bulls of pure breed have been received from the government of India, said the ministry.

Similarly, 101 heifers of advanced breed and eight bulls of high reproductive breed have been received from the government of South Korea.

Likewise, 986,000 doses of frozen semen have been produced and distributed for the improvement of animal breeds. The National Animal Breeding Office constructed a semen production and processing laboratory in Lahan.

According to the ministry, 82 tonnes of haylage produced in Nepal has been exported to China for the first time while 1,686 tonnes of chhurpi (dog or cat food) worth about Rs.3.7 billion has been exported.

A Memorandum of Understanding was signed with the Government of China, the Government of South Korea and the International Maize and Wheat Improvement Centre regarding the import of development technology in the agricultural sector and the trade of agricultural produce, while a similar agreement with the Government of India is in the final stage.

Similarly, irrigation facilities were expanded to around 5,039 hectares of land by constructing irrigation canal systems along with the structure of various surface irrigation projects in a year.

High level body sought to...

to cut the electricity of the industries which were paying regular bills even during the disputed period.

He said that now there was a dispute only over the additional bill, adding that it was not appropriate move of the Nepal Electricity Authority to cut the line.

He also demanded an immediate solution to the dispute by reconnecting the lines of the industries where the power supply was cut off.

On that occasion, Dhruba Thapa, President of Nepal Cement Producers' Association, said that it was regrettable that the electricity of the industries, which were running at only 30 per cent of their capacity due to the crisis, had been cut off.

The work of NEA to cut electricity of the industries would affect the employment, he said.

On Sunday, the Authority cut the lines of Sarbottam Cement, Laxmi Steel, Ashok Steel, Sonapur Minerals and Oil Pvt Ltd and Triveni Spinning Mills.

Similarly, the lines of Jagdamba Steels, Reliance Spinning Mills, Ghorahi Cement and Arghakhanchi Cement were cut off on Friday.

The electricity tariff arrears under the dedicated line of Jagdamba Steels stood at Rs. 4.14 billion, Reliance Spinning Mills at Rs. 1.94 billion, Ghorahi Cement at Rs. 1.36 billion and Arghakhanchi Cement at Rs. 1.3 billion, said the NEA.

According to the Authority, under the dedicated and trunk lines, 61 industries have to pay arrears amounting to over Rs. 22 billion.

Amendment to National Parks and Wildlife Conservation Act 2029 sought

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The Federation of Community Forestry Users Nepal (FECOFUN) and the Nepal Federation of Indigenous Nationalities (NEFIN) have jointly demanded an amendment to the National Parks and Wildlife Conservation Act 2029.

Speaking at a programme organised on Sunday, the officials of both the FECOFUN and NEFIN handed over the suggestions and position papers to the Secretary of the Ministry of Forest and Environment, Deepak Kumar Kharal.

According to them, the existing laws have not been able to address the demands of indigenous and local citizens, and they need timely amendments.

Along with the Act, the National Parks and Wildlife Conservation Regulations 2080, Procedures for Construction of Infrastructure in Protected Areas 2080, Standards for Professionally Keeping, Breeding and Utilisation of Wildlife 2080 and Guidelines for Relief and Distribution of Damages Caused by Wildlife 2080 have been submitted.

Their demand is not to displace the indigenous and local communities living around the protected areas in the name of protected areas. The indigenous leaders asked the officials to address the legitimate demands of the communities, which have been using the resources since ancient times.

The government of Nepal should immediately commit that conservation of biological diversity will be done through community-based protected areas and customary institutions, including community forests," the demand letter stated. They are also demanding the draft of a new law related to the management of protected areas in consultation with the indigenous people living around the national parks and addressing their rights.

Since citizens are suffering from wild animals in the protected areas, they have also arranged for proper compensation for all those who lost their lives in the attacks of wild animals.

Gelje Sherpa, president of NEFIN, demanded the creation of a protected area only after ensuring the rights of the people. He said that the life of wild animals could not be greater than the people, he asked to ensure the rights of the local people first.

Chairman of Indigenous Commission Ram Bahadur Thapa Magar said that indigenous people should not be displaced as their lives are connected with land and forest.

Informing that the commission has received complaints about the displacement of many indigenous people by parks and hydropower projects, he said that he would discuss with the government and stakeholders and try to find a solution.

Sindhu Prasad Dhungana, Director General of the Department of National Parks and Wildlife Conservation, said that there should be arrangements according to the wishes of the people in a democracy.

He said that the Act has already been amended five times and further amendments may be made in the future. He said that the government should also protect the knowledge, skills and customs of the indigenous communities.

Pakistani police free 290 Baloch activists

AP
Islamabad, Dec. 25

Pakistani police Monday freed 290 Baloch activists who were arrested when they attempted to hold a protest last week in the capital, Islamabad.

Their release came days after protest organizers gave authorities a deadline to release all those detained.

The activists had traveled 1,600 kilometers (about 1,000 miles) on Thursday from Turbat, a town in Baluchistan province, to protest forced disappearances and extrajudicial killings in the militancy-ravaged southwest.

The protesters were mostly women and some had brought along their children, aged 7-12, when security forces used batons and water canons to disperse and arrest them.

They wanted to draw attention to the case of 24-year-old Balaach Mola Bakhsh, who died in November while in police custody in Baluchistan. Authorities said he was killed after militants ambushed the police vehicle transporting him.

Police said Bakhsh was carrying explosives when he was arrested. His family insists he is innocent,



PHOTO: AP

Baloch activists hold the portraits of their missing family members during their sit-in protest, in Islamabad, Pakistan, Monday.

demanding justice for him. They also said he had been detained since October. Police said they arrested him in November.

The police use of force against the protesters sparked anger among Baluchistan residents and drew nationwide condemnation from top human rights activists.

Protest organizers said that as the dozens of vehicles carrying the activists reached the outskirts of Islamabad before dawn Thursday, police used water canons against them and started beating them up to prevent them from reaching the heart of the capital.

At the weekend, organizers and protesters held a sit-in outside the Islamabad Press Club to denounce the violence.

"Four female police officers with batons hit me," Mahrang Baloch, one of the organizers, told reporters as she and dozens of others held portraits of those detained by the police, demanding their release.

Senator Mushtaq Ahmed and top human rights activist Farhat Ullah Baba attended the sit-in and condemned the use of force by authorities.

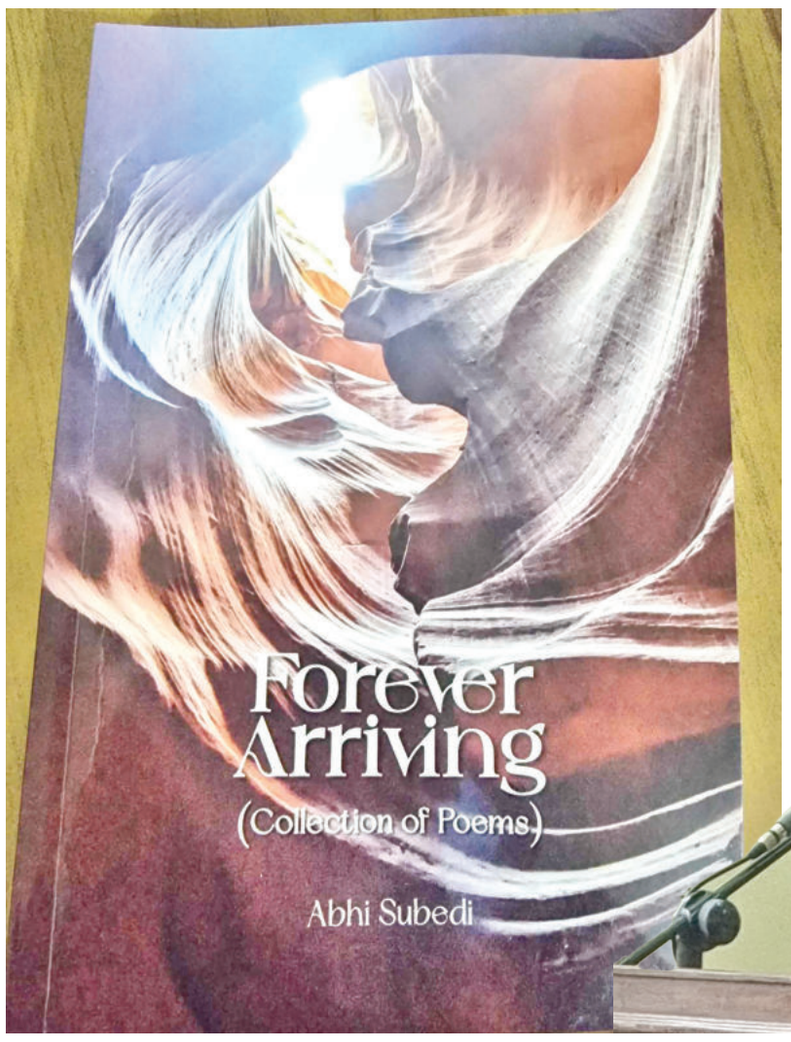
"These peaceful demonstrators are victims of state terrorism," Ahmed said, adding that every citizen had the right to peacefully protest in Pakistan.

Baluchistan province — which borders Afghanistan and Iran and is rich in oil, gas and minerals — has been the scene of low-level insurgency by Baluch nationalists for more than two decades. Baluch nationalists initially wanted a share of provincial resources, but later initiated an insurgency for independence.

According to human rights activists, those who demand a greater share of the province's natural resources often go missing after being detained by security forces.

Abhi's 'Forever Arriving' Comes Out

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25



Professor Abhi Subedi has brought a collection of English poems titled 'Forever Arriving' that reflects his creative journey spanning over half a century.

The book was unveiled amid a programme attended by a galaxy of writers and literary aficionados here on Monday. The anthology, according to the poet, evokes different moments of his life's journey.

Published by Mandala Book Point, the book comprises a total of 60 poems that catch the moods and emotions of different times and places.

"I have written poems in both English and Nepali, but I have written more in English," said the poet. He recited a few of his poems and shared the stories and experiences behind creating them. "I gained exposure to English literature with my encounters with hippies," recounted Subedi.

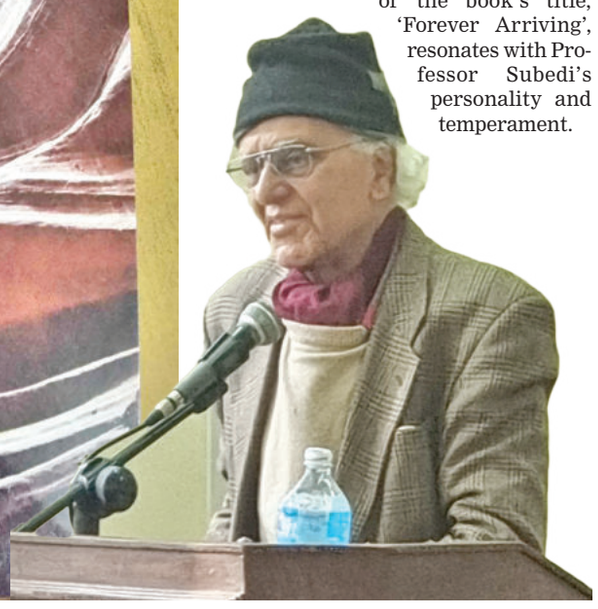
Professor Mohan Prasad Lohani said that the poet equated his creativity with performativity. "The anthology serves as an inspiration to aspiring poets and encourages them to read the poems for a better understanding of the artistic creativity."

Dr Arun Gupto said Abhi's poems manifested profound and mysterious metaphors and romantic vision.

Motikala Subba Dewan, president of the Nepal English Language Teachers' Association (NELTA), said that Subedi's poems traversed locations from Edinburgh, Scotland through Germany, Japan, Italy and many other countries to Nepal. She added that the poet did not stick to conventional poetic elements like simile and metaphor. "Instead, he chooses free verse for spontaneous expression of his feelings and thoughts."

His style provides the freedom of expression and avoids binding to conventional modes of composing poems, she said. "Free verse is a powerful technique of expression. This is a reason why Subedi's poems have natural expressions that directly revolt against societal norms, including patriarchy and prejudice prevalent in various forms."

Dr. Shiva Rijal said that the spirit of the book's title, 'Forever Arriving', resonates with Professor Subedi's personality and temperament.



Arbaaz Khan, Sshura Khan get married



AGENCIES
Mumbai, Dec. 25

Actor-producer Arbaaz Khan and make-up artist Sshura Khan exchanged vows in an intimate ceremony on Sunday. Surrounded by close family and friends, they tied the nuptial knot at the residence of Arbaaz's sister, Arpita Khan Sharma, in the presence of their loved ones.

Arbaaz took to his official Instagram page on Monday morning to share the initial glimpses of the wedding, expressing gratitude for the presence of loved ones and seeking blessings for the new chapter in their lives.

The newlyweds chose floral ensembles for the occasion, with Arbaaz elegantly clad in a bandhgala sherwani, and Sshura stunning in a pink pastel organza lehenga. Among the attendees were Arbaaz's son Arhaan, parents Salim Khan and Salma Khan, stepmother Helen, brothers Salman Khan and Sohail Khan, nephew Nirvaan Khan, sister Alvira Khan Agnihotri, and brother-in-law Atul Agnihotri. Notable guests included Iulia Vantur and Raveena Tandon.

This marriage marks a new beginning for Arbaaz, who was previously married to model-actor Malaika Arora for 19 years. Before tying the knot with Sshura, he had been in a relationship with model Giorgia Andriani.

Gulaf's world premiere in Nepal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25



The theatrical journey of the drama 'Gulaf' (The Rose) is set to commence in Nepal, with its world premiere scheduled for December 27, next year at Mandala Theatre, Thapa Gaon, Kathmandu.

The play is also set to tour various European cities.

Conceived and directed by Ram Hari Dhakal, a seasoned theatre practitioner with over two decades of experience in the theatre, 'Gulaf' falls under the genre of 'physical theatre', where the narrative unfolds without traditional dialogue, relying on scenes to convey the story.

Titled 'The Rose: An Awakening Journey of Yashodhara' in English, this unique play explores the emotional turmoil of Yashodhara, the wife of Prince Siddharth Gautam, who embarks on a quest for answers, leaving behind his newborn son Rahul. What sets 'Gulaf' apart is not just its unconventional genre but also the interactive stage design.

The stage is positioned in the centre of the theatre, allowing the audience to observe the performance from all angles. Each show accommodates only 64 spectators.

The central theme of the play revolves around Yashodhara's emotional journey from the anguish and separation caused by Siddharth Gautam's departure to her eventual awakening.

The play delves into Yashodhara's internal struggles and transformations, expressed through physical performances.

The lead roles of Yashodhara are portrayed by Deeya Maskey and Sarita Sah.

The production boasts a talented team, including sound designer Dev Neupan, lighting designer Umesh Tamang, costume designer Sanjita Parajuli, stage constructor Hum BC, cover artist Anamika Gautam, and stage manager Kedar Shrestha. Assistant roles are handled by Bal Bahadur Rai, Kapaseli Thito, Tirtha Vishwakarma, Sasmil Poon Magar and Eeksa Maden Limbu.

The world premiere of 'Gulaf' is scheduled for 4 pm on December 27 , with daily performances (excluding Mondays) continuing until January 7. Saturday shows will be staged at 1 pm.

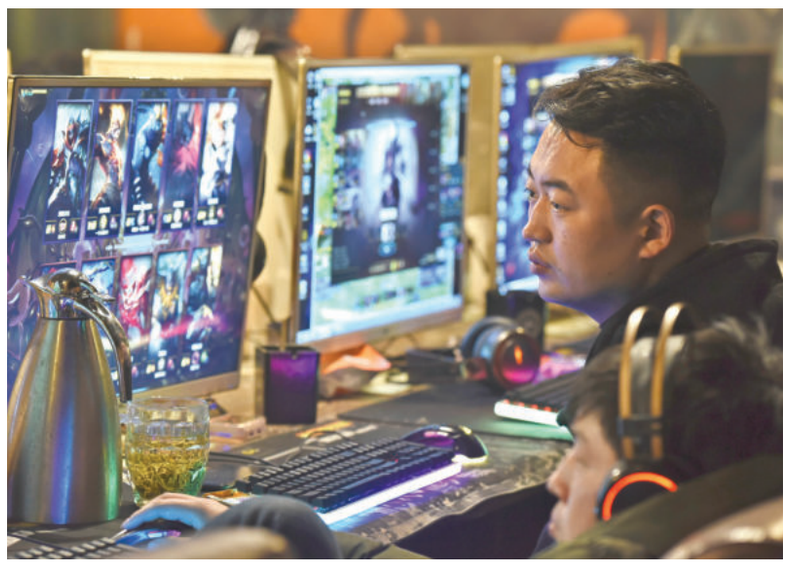
This production, presented by Thetna Arts and Mandala Theatre, receives support from Art and Culture Norway, Nordisk Culture Fund, and FfukNo.

In Nepal, Gurukul, Actors' Studio, and Theatre Mall are contributing to the success of the performances.

Director Dhakal earlier presented three consecutive sensory plays (Sensory Theater) in Nepal. Only in July this year, he staged the sensory play 'Chakra' (The Wheel) at Mandala Theater.

China approves 105 online games after draft curbs trigger massive losses

AP
Bangkok , Dec. 25



China's press and publications authority has approved 105 new online games, saying it fully supports the industry after proposed curbs caused massive losses last week for investors in major games makers.

The National Press and Publication Administration issued a statement on its WeChat social media account Monday saying the approvals by the Game Working Committee of China Music and Digital Association were "positive signals that support the prosperity and healthy development of the online game industry." Tencent's "Counter War: Future" and NetEase's "Firefly Assault" were among games approved.

Draft guidelines for curbs on online gaming had caused share prices of video game makers like Tencent and Netease to plunge on Friday, causing losses of tens of billions of dollars and dragging Chinese benchmarks lower.

The administration's guidelines said online games would be banned from offering incentives for daily log-ins or purchases. Other restrictions include limiting how much users can recharge and issuing warnings for "irrational consumption behavior."

On Friday, Netease's Nasdaq-traded shares fell 16.1% while it's Hong Kong-traded shares sank 25%. Tencent's closed 12% lower. Huya Inc., a smaller online games maker, lost 10.7% on the New York Stock Exchange. Overall, the companies lost tens of billions of dollars in market value.

Hong Kong's market was closed Monday for the Christmas holiday. Share prices in Shanghai were flat.

The Press and Publication Administration said that in 2023, 1,075 game version numbers had been issued, of which 977 were domestically produced and 98 were imported.

It also cited a "2023 China Game Industry Report" that it said showed sales revenue for the domestic online games market exceeded 300 billion yuan ($42 billion) in 2023, with the number of people playing the games reaching 668 million.

"The Game Working Committee hopes that member units will take this opportunity to launch more high-quality products, promote high-quality development of the online game industry, and contribute to promoting cultural prosperity and development and building a culturally powerful country," it said.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Home is where the heart is -- at least for this moment. The Full Moon is illuminating your 4th House of Family, reminding you of your immediate surroundings and bringing your foundations into sharper focus.

Taurus: A special current is whipping through the air in your direction. The cosmic energy is speeding up, hurried along by the Full Moon in your 3rd House of Chatter. People and information are both coming your way, all clamoring for your attention.

Gemini: Glittering abundance is all around you at the moment. Money is potentially taking on extra importance as your 2nd House of Wages glows with a brilliant Full Moon, bringing you some amazing opportunities to manifest plenty of wealth.

Cancer: Your desires can take precedence over everything else. This doesn't have to be selfish; you've got every right to focus on your needs, due to the Full Moon landing in your 1st House of the Self.

Leo: Reality? Who needs it! As your 12th House of Fantasy plays host to the potent Full Moon, you've got a permission slip from the universe to check out from reality. Let your soul drift at its natural pace, clearing out things which no longer serve you along the way.

Virgo: Aren't you the popular one! Your social net worth is rising -- just like the powerful Full Moon rising in your 11th House of Global Networks, making this the perfect window to connect with people near and far.

Libra: Someone important is demanding your attention. Your partnerships are coming into sharper focus as today's Full Moon emboldens your 7th House of Relationships, encouraging you to find balance and harmony.

Scorpio: The world is your oyster, Scorpio! There is a fantastic Full Moon shining in your 9th House of Adventure, encouraging you to spread your wings and see just how far you can fly in your search for excitement and satisfaction.

Sagittarius: No one ever said life was easy. You may need to face this unpleasant truth as a Full Moon spotlights your 8th House of Transformation, inviting you to step up and prove your mettle in order to become a better version of yourself.

Capricorn: The cosmic green light is on, and it's your turn to go. The Sun is blasting into your 1st House of Self-Expression, announcing your cosmically mandated time of year to get in touch with your own goals and desires and ensure.

Aquarius: Self-improvement is the name of the game right now. You're ready to be your best self, due to the Full Moon landing in your 6th House of Wellness, making this the perfect time to get yourself.

Pisces: It's your time to shine where everyone can see you! You can thank the glorious Full Moon in your creative 5th house for that. This is a very artistic, expressive moment for you, so even if you're normally one to keep.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Dhangadhi beat Pokhara in penalty, advance to NSL final



PHOTO: BIKASH DWARE/TRN

The heroics from Goalkeeper Mohamad Taha in the penalty shootout sent Dhangadhi to the final for the second season in a row.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Dhangadhi FC prevailed over Pokhara Thunders 4-3 in the penalty shootout in the thrilling Qualifier 1 at Dashrath Stadium on Monday to advance into the final of the Nepal Super League.

Dhangadhi bounced back twice to level the score the equalizer in the regular 90-minute and extra time to force the match into a penalty shootout.

Pokhara squandered the early lead provided by Ayush Ghalan to concede an equalizer in the second half from Dhangadhi captain Devendra Tamang. As the regulation time ended in a 1-1 tie, the extra 30 minutes was added.

Pokhara regained their lead in the extra time too with Franklin Kuete Talla finding the net. But Dhangadhi again managed to level the score line from Ahmad Hijaji and took the match into a penalty.

The heroics from Goalkeeper Mohamad Taha in the penalty shootout sent Dhangadhi to the final for the second season in a row. Taha saved the spot kick of Moses Gyabaah and Ayush Ghalan. Pokhara's keeper Priso warded off the kick of Hijaji.

After both teams tied 1-1 in the scheduled 90 minutes, the match was extended to 30 minutes of extra time.

In the first half, Pokhara took the lead in the game. However, from the beginning of the second half, Dhangadhi's relentless attack paid off, ultimately resulting in an equalizer.

In the third minute of the game, Mohammad Taha, the goalkeeper of Dhangadhi, saved Franklin Talla's header after Pokhara's Suraj Jiu Thakuri's corner was cleared.

In the fifth minute, Pokhara managed to take the lead. Stephan Annor's long pass was met by Moses Twum on the left flank, and he crossed it for Dipesh Ale Magar, who deflected the ball in front of Ayush. Ayush made no mistakes and scored, giving Pokhara the lead.

Dhangadhi captain Devendra Tamang levelled the tally in the 54th minute.

Ahmed Hijaji's shot from the edge of the box was saved by Pokhara keeper Priso for a corner. Dhangadhi scored the equalizer in that resulting corner. Kamal Shrestha crossed the corner ball off Abhishek Gurung to Devendra, who dived to head the equalizer.

As no goal was possible from both the teams in the remaining time of regulation time, the match went to the extra 30 minutes.

Pokhara regained the lead in the 103 minute through Franklin Kuete Talla. After Dinesh Rajbanshi's two shots on Suraj Jiu Thakuri's cross were saved by Dhangadhi goalkeeper Taha, Talla headed the rebound towards the post which was finally turned into a goal by Stefan Annor 's head.

Hijaji scored in the last minute (120) of the extra time to push the game to the penalty shootout. He scored a goal in his second attempt after his first shot was blocked by captain Dinesh. In the resulting rebound, Lebanese Hijaji made no mistake sending the ball between the two sticks.

Defending Champions Kathmandu Rayzrs and Lalitpur City FC will meet each other in the eliminator round on Tuesday looking at their meeting with Pokhara Thunders at the Qualifier 2. The winner of the Qualifier 2 will fix the final date with Dhangadhi on Saturday.

APF prevail over Koshi, Madhesh bag first win at PM Cup



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The Armed Police Force (APF) Club has won their fourth consecutive match while Sudurpaschim Province has registered their third match in a row at the Prime Minister Cup Women's T20 National Cricket tournament held on Monday. Madhesh Province also bagged their first match while Lumbini Province won their second match on the same day.

In the match between the title favorites at Upper Mulpani cricket ground, APF won by eight wickets against Koshi Province. Koshi Province batted first and scored 84/2 in 20 overs. APF, in reply, lost two wickets and won the match in 17.3 overs with 90 runs on the board. National team captain Indu Barma top-scored with an unbeaten 36 runs while Jyoti Pandey (24) and Captain Sita Rana Magar (18) also contributed to the win of APF. With four wins in a row, APF is at the top with eight points, while Koshi is in second place with six points after suffering their first loss in four matches.

Sudurpaschim Province won by six wickets against Bagmati Province at TU Cricket Ground. Bagmati Province struggled to collect 87 runs losing eight wickets in 20 overs. Laxmi Saud and Kabita Joshi dismissed two batters each for Sudurpaschim. Bindu Rawal (28) and Kabita Joshi (not out 27) steered Sudurpaschim to their third win. With back-to-back wins, Sudurpaschim is in third place with six points, falling behind Koshi in net run rate. Bagmati Province is in fourth place with four points.

Madhesh Province defeated Gandaki Province by 27 runs in the match at Upper Mulpani Cricket Ground. Puja Mahato's 38 and Saraswati Kumari's not out 26 helped Madhesh to amass 112/7 in 20 overs. Gandaki, who suffered their third defeat, was bundled out to 85 runs with two balls to spare. Suman Khatiwada, who dismissed three batters of Madhesh, smashed 33-ball 42 from the middle but her batting went in vain as she could not get a stable partner. All-rounder Mahato was the major destroyer of Gandaki's batting with a three-wicket haul.

Lumbini Province beat Karnali Province by 30 runs in another match at the TU Cricket Ground. Karnali Province, who chased the target of 134 runs presented by Lumbini Province for victory, managed to score only 103 runs for the loss of seven wickets in 20 overs. For Karnali, Gauri Bohra (22) and Opener Yamuna Tharu (21) are the top contributors with the bat. Lumbini's Saraswati Pun and Kritika Marasini took two wickets in the restriction of Karnali. With the win, Lumbini Province has scored four points from four games and is in fifth place. Karnali Province, with four consecutive losses, is at the bottom without any points.

FIFA THREATENS TO SUSPEND BRAZIL

AP
Rio De Janeiro, Dec. 25

FIFA warned Brazil on Sunday it could suspend its national teams and clubs from international competitions if an intervention by its soccer body leads to the election of a new president in January.

FIFA said in a letter to a Brazilian soccer executive that the country's soccer body CBF could face suspension if it does not heed its call to wait and instead holds a swift election to replace Ednaldo Rodrigues as president regardless. The document was obtained by The Associated Press.

A Rio de Janeiro court removed Rodrigues and all his appointees at CBF from office on Dec. 7 due to irregularities in his election last year. Brazil's two highest courts upheld that ruling last week.

Soccer's governing body FIFA historically rejects government and third-party interference in its member associations, which ultimately could leave five-time World Cup winners Brazil out of major competitions until the crisis is solved.

The Rio court ruling also named José Perdiz, the head of Brazil's top sports court, as an intervener to organize new elections for the presidency within 30 working days. FIFA said in previous letters to CBF it considers the intervention to be undue.

Sunday's letter was signed by FIFA's Kenny Jean-Marie, its chief members' association officer, and CONMEBOL's deputy secretary-general, Monserrat Jiménez Garcia.

Wolves inflict Christmas misery on Chelsea

AFP
Wolverhampton, Dec. 25

Wolves condemned Chelsea to a fourth defeat in six league matches on Sunday, winning 2-1 in the first Christmas Eve Premier League match since 1995.

Mauricio Pochettino's men dominated possession at Molineux but wasted chances in an incident-packed game littered with careless defensive errors by the visiting side.

Wolves appeared to be cantering to victory after goals from Mario Lemina and Matt Doherty but they were made to sweat when Christopher Nkunku pulled one back deep into stoppage time on his Premier League debut.

The defeat means Chelsea are stuck in 10th in the Premier League, with Wolves behind them only on goal difference.

No side have lost more Premier League matches in 2023 than Chelsea's tally of 19, while only three sides have lost more across the big five European leagues during the calendar year.

Pochettino bemoaned his team's missed chances after a frustrating afternoon.

"We feel very disappointed because I think we deserve much more," the Argentine told Sky Sports. "This competition wounds you when you are not clinical enough.

"We created chances. That is why it is so disappointing. We conceded after a few corners and it was really difficult."

He added: "We were talking a lot at the beginning of the season. We are young in age. It is a young team. We have players playing for the first time in the league. They need to adapt. It is confidence and about quality."

Missed chances

There were chances at both ends early in the game.

Nelson Samedo burst forward but could not find Matheus Cunha on the left before Armando Broja stumbled on the ball in the box at the other end when well placed.

Chelsea's Nicolas Jackson was also guilty of failing to make the most of some good openings.



The visitors wasted a gilt-edged opportunity to take the lead shortly after the half-hour mark when Raheem Sterling caught Joao Gomes in possession 40 yards out and drove forward.

The England forward was one-on-one with Jose Sa, with two team-mates to his right, but he opted to shoot rather than pass and it was saved by the Wolves goalkeeper.

Wolves had a chance to break the deadlock in the closing moments of the half when Hwang Hee-chan burst through but he blasted over from an angle.

The home side started the second half brightly and came within a whisker of taking the lead when Chelsea's Lesley Ugochukwu deflected Gomes's shot onto the outside of the post.

But Wolves broke the deadlock in the 51st minute when Lemina did not even need to get off the ground to head home a Pablo Sarabia corner.

Substitute Nkunku came close to equalising when his shot was hacked off the line by Toti.

Instead, Wolves doubled their lead in stoppage time.

Substitute Hugo Bueno crossed and Chelsea were only able to block the ball as far as the waiting Doherty, who finished calmly from close range in the 93rd minute.

France international Nkunku pulled one back when he headed home three minutes later but Gary O'Neil's side hung on to take all three points.

Goalscorer Doherty praised the fans for creating a crackling atmosphere.

"Our record against top-six teams is good," he said. "We've beaten most of them here and away.

WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:53 am, Sunset at 5:16 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.7	5.3	0.0
Dipayal	24.0	6.7	0.0
Dhangadi	25.9	9.5	0.0
Birendranagar	23.5	6.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	25.2	11.0	0.0
Jumla	17.4	-2.8	0.0
Ghorahi	23.2	9.4	0.0
Pokhara	22.6	9.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.7	11.6	0.0
Simara	27.8	11.0	0.0
Kathmandu	18.7	5.4	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.4	8.6	0.0
Taplejung	17.8	7.0	0.0
Dhankuta	24.0	10.8	0.0
Biratnagar	27.4	12.5	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.4	15.4	0.0*
Lumle	17.0	6.2	0.0*
Janakpur	31.0	12.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.1	3.0	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 26, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.73	Rs. 133.33
Euro	1	Rs. 146.20	Rs. 146.86
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.53	Rs. 169.29
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 154.99	Rs. 155.69
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.39	Rs. 90.80
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.12	Rs. 100.58
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.26	Rs.100.72
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.32	Rs. 9.37
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.60	Rs. 18.68
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.39	Rs. 35.55
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.31	Rs. 36.48
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.84	Rs. 3.86
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.30
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.66	Rs. 28.78
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.23	Rs. 10.28
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.25	Rs. 13.31
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.61	Rs. 19.70
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.00	Rs. 17.07
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.09	Rs. 434.05
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.08	Rs. 353.67

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Australia unchanged for 2nd Test, Pakistan drop veteran Ahmed

AFP
Melbourne, Dec. 25

Australia named an unchanged XI on Monday for the Boxing Day Test at the Melbourne Cricket Ground as they look to seal the series against Pakistan, who dropped veteran wicketkeeper-batter Sarfaraz Ahmed.

The hosts crushed Shan Masood's side by 360 runs inside four days at the first Test in Perth, with pace spearheads Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood all coming through unscathed.

It means Scott Boland, who took 6-7 on debut at the MCG against England in 2021, misses out.

"We're a huge fan of Scotty, I don't think that's a secret," skipper Cummins told reporters on a wet Christmas Day.

"He's ready to go if anything happens, so I'm sure he'll play a part at some point.

"The message (to Boland) is always 'we love what you bring, unfortunately, you miss out on this one but don't change, keep working hard and make sure you stay ready'."

Showers and potential thunderstorms are expected for the first day of play but are forecast to clear by Wednesday afternoon and Cummins said he was confident of a result.

"I think there will be plenty of time to finish the game. I don't think (the weather) will change anything," he said.

"(The wicket) looks pretty good. Fair bit of grass, probably a little bit harder and not as green as last year."

Pakistan have been hit hard by injuries since Perth with fast bowler Khurram Shahzad and their two leading spinners, Abrar Ahmed and Noman Ali, all ruled out of the Melbourne match.

They named a 12-man squad with Sarfaraz Ahmed and speedster Faheem Ashraf axed.

Mohammad Nawaz will take the gloves, with Mir Hamza and Hasan Ali in contention for Shahzad's place in the attack alongside veteran Shaheen Shah Afridi and impressive newcomer Aamer Jamal.

With Ahmed and Ali sidelined, Sajid Khan is their only spin option.

"We think Rizwan is ready and we can give Sarfaraz a little bit of a break to recoup and come back," said Masood.

"It's more of a tactical decision in terms of the conditions and what we can get out of each player."

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PM TO ADDRESS THE NATION TODAY



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda is set to address the nation on Tuesday. According to the Prime Minister's Secretariat, he will be addressing the nation from 5:00 pm.

He is scheduled to address the nation, marking the completion of one

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PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Students walking home from their school in Thaha Municipality of Makawanpur district.

Major parties agree to advance TRC Bill

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec 25:

A meeting of the top leaders of three major political parties held at the Prime Minister's official residence in Baluwatar this evening ended with an agreement to pass the Bill on Commission on Investigation of Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation (TRC) from the upcoming winter session of the Federal Parliament.

Parliamentary approval of the TRC Bill will be a breakthrough in completing the remaining tasks of the country's peace process.

According to the PM's Personal Secretary Ramesh Malla, the top leaders of the three major political parties agreed to advance the bill on Commission on Investigation of Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation, which is in the parliamentary committee and pass it from the winter session of the parliament with priority for making the laws relating to transitional justice.

Talking briefly to the media after the meeting, CPN (UML)'s parliamentary party whip Mahesh Bartaula said the top leaders agreed to make victim-centric laws.

"The UML is ready to go for a consensus if we are to make the victim-centric laws. The PM has expressed his readiness to address this issue from the winter session," Bartaula mentioned.

Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chair Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba, CPN (UML) Chair KP Sharma Oli, Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka, Minister for Law Dhanraj Gurung and other leaders of the three parties were present at the meeting summoned by the Prime Minister.

Smooth supply of fertilizer elates farmers

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The government has been giving priority to the supply of chemical fertilisers and other agricultural inputs in a bid to increase production and productivity of the agriculture sector.

In a year after the formation of the present government under the leadership of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on December 25, 2022, the government imported almost 500,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers.

According to the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development, the government has distributed more than 400,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers to the farmers in a year.

With the improvement in the supply of chemical fertilisers, the farmers across the country have been able to get the chemical fertilisers as per their needs during the time of paddy plantation and to grow winter crops like wheat and potatoes, said Sabnam Shivakoti, spokesperson for the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development.

Goma Adhikari of Panchkhal Municipality-7, Kavrepalanchowk, said that they received the required amount of chemical fertilisers for potato cultivation.

Recalling the acute shortage of chemical fertilisers during the paddy cultivation time in the summer and to grow potatoes in winter last year, she said that the farmers did not face any shortage of chemical fertilisers this year.

Last year, the farmers not only in Panchkhal but also elsewhere were forced to stand in queue for hours to get 5-10 kg of fertilisers.

"As farmers, we expect an easy supply of chemical fertilisers, seeds and tools and proper management of markets to sell our produce. So, I want to give thanks to the government for managing a smooth supply of chemical fertilisers. We also expect subsidies for these goods," she said.

One Year of Government

Even though the government has increased the supply of chemical fertilisers, the present supply is not enough. The government study showed that at least 700,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers are required annually.



The government has allocated Rs. 30 billion to provide subsidies to the farmers on chemical fertilisers.

Shivakoti said that the procurement process for chemical fertilisers would be improved and the supply and distribution process of the fertilisers would be made systematic and transparent.

The process of establishing a chemical fertiliser factory within the country has also moved ahead.

Development on crop seeds, livestock vaccination

According to the Ministry, the seed production cycle has been expanded by establishing 13 resource centres and producing 1,000 tonnes of source seeds of various crops.

In the last year, 22 varieties of various crops including rice, wheat, corn, and vegetables have been registered for source seeds and the seeds of six varieties have been released.

To provide technical services at farmers' doorstep, 397 people have been mobilised as agricultural graduates, veterinary doctors, agricultural technicians and animal service specialists at the local levels through conditional grants.

According to the Ministry, the area to cultivate fruits, vegetables, potatoes, coffee and spices has been expanded to 2,412 hectares by providing subsidies to attract farmers towards cash crop farming.

The minimum support price of rice has been fixed at Rs. 3,198 per quintal for coarse rice and Rs. 3,362 per quintal for medium rice and accordingly, 37,000 tonnes of paddy have been purchased through Food Management and Trading Company and 15,000 through cooperatives at the minimum support price.

The minimum purchase price of sugarcane this year has also been fixed at Rs. 635 per quintal.

During the year, around 181,965 crop and livestock insurance policies have been issued and crops and livestock worth Rs. 50 billion have been insured, according to the ministry.

A total of Rs. 2.12 billion, including Rs. 1.96 billion under livestock insurance and Rs. 159 million under agriculture insurance has been paid.

According to the ministry, the vaccination programme was conducted by producing 53.8 million doses of 13 different types of vaccines for the control of infectious diseases of livestock.

In the meantime, the government has facilitated the import of 1.37 million doses of vaccine to control lumpy skin disease, and around 351,000 animals have been vaccinated against the lumpy skin disease.

Rules, regulations and standards

According to the ministry, after approving the (First Amendment) Standard, 2079 regarding providing relief for items destroyed during bird flu control, an amount of Rs. 580 million

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I will do justice to all party leaders: Deuba

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Dec. 25

Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the party will maintain full justice while distributing the election tickets.



Inaugurating the NC Tanahun district conference in Damauli on Monday, Deuba said justice would be given to those who did not get the election tickets earlier and those who were not getting them now would get it in the future.

Deuba also inaugurated the BP Memorial Building constructed by the NC Tanahun District Committee.

Stressing for unity in the party by sacrificing differences, he said to build the party-unity strong, justice would be provided while distributing tickets in the election of the National Assembly.

Deuba also underlined the need for consensus among political parties stating that no party could garner a majority in the election due to the inclusive proportional system provisioned in the constitution.

"We have to strengthen the Federal Democratic Republic system by forging consensus," he said.

Deuba said although the NC did not garner a majority in the parliament due to the constitutional provision, it emerged as the largest party and it should move ahead with reconciliation.

"It is difficult for a single party to garner a majority in the parliament due to constitutional provision introduced to ensure representation of all castes, genders, communities and geographies, so there is no alternative to developing consensus with other parties to form the government," he said.

Deuba further stressed consensus between political parties to conclude the peace process and the crises facing the country.

Likewise, Deuba released a souvenir published by the NC Tahanun.

In the souvenir, the names of 1847 persons who donated to build the BP Memorial Building were mentioned. The building that covers an area of 8 aana of land was constructed at Rs. Rs. 17,200,000.

He also garlanded the BP's statute reaching BP Park in Byas Municipality-3, from where BP Koirala, in 1979, announced that the status of all Nepali should be made the same with one residence, a milking cow, a pair of oxen, enough food for morning and evening, money to educate children and buy medicines.

High level body sought to resolve power supply issue

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) has demanded formation of a high-level commission to resolve the arrears disputes of trunk and dedicated lines.

Issuing a press statement regarding a long-standing dispute related to the dedicated and trunk lines arrears on Monday, the FNCCI demanded a powerful commission to resolve the dispute between the Authority and the industrialists.

FNCCI showed its serious attention to the fact that power lines of industries were cut without resolving the disputes related to the payment of dedicated and trunk lines connected to industries.

The FNCCI demanded that a commission, having representatives also from private sector, should be formed to give an impartial opinion after analysing the past studies, current situation and Time of the Day (TOD) metres, among others.

The Federation has requested the Nepal Electricity Authority and other related agencies to reconnect the electricity supply of the industries Until a final decision is made on the issue. It also requested the NEA not to cut the lines of other industries.

"If this issue is not addressed immediately, industries will be shut down, and it will affect employment and revenue. During the current economic recession, the Federation is confident that the government will take initiatives to solve the problem by taking the issues of the private sector seriously," said the FNCCI.

Meanwhile, the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) has emphasised that the dispute over dedicated and trunk lines, which has been going on for a long time, should be resolved immediately through discussion rather than inviting a tussle.

Organising a press conference on Monday evening, President of CNI Rajesh Kumar Agrawal said that the disputes on the arrears of dedicated lines should be addressed adopting a middle way.

He said that it was not appropriate

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Newar community marks Yomari Punhi today

BY SUSHMA MAHARJAN
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Yomari Punhi is a major festival of the Newars in Kathmandu. 'Yomari' means favourite confection in the Newari language. It is celebrated annually on the full moon of the Nepali month of Mangsir.

On the occasion, the people of the Newar community prepare a special delicacy called yomari, a closed cone-shaped cuisine made of rice flour filled with molasses and sesame seeds.

The festival also marks the end of the harvesting season.

Sunita Maharjan, a local from Kilagal, said that she celebrates by cleaning her house, performing puja and offering yomari to the god and goddess early in the morning. Afterwards, she prepares a feast for her family.

According to Maharjan, yomari is made from the flour of the first harvested paddy and offered to the paddy bhakari, a traditional container for storing food grains. This is done with prayers for the harvested grain to be sufficient for the family throughout the year. She said that people celebrate by performing 'tyo-si-tyo', a tradition, where groups visit houses in the



community singing folklore.

Upon their arrival, the house owners gift them yomari, fruits and other items and in return the group bless them with good fortune and life, Sunita said.

According to her, the tyo-si-tyo carries traditional and cultural values.

She said, "Newar people value sharing food and celebrating festivals with family and friends. Historically, yomari was a rare food prepared once a year. Thus, people used to play tyo-si-tyo and share yomari in the community."

Furthermore, making yomari is considered a way to showcase skills of housewives. Yomari's unique cone shape featuring a head and tail allows for artistic expression. The tail can be elongated and the head can be shaped into figures like birds, one horn and two horns or even flattened.

There is a belief that the longer the tail of the yomari, the longer the day will become from that day onward. Additionally, the delicacy is nutritionally valued since it is made of rice flour and sweet ingredients that help generate body heat.

Meanwhile, some people now celebrate the festival at their convenience due to busy lifestyles.

Sahayog Ranjit, a local, said that his family celebrates when they find free time. He said at least one festival falls every month in a Newar community. He said, "I and my family members are employed. We don't have enough time to prepare for the feast. Thus, we call a gathering of the closed family when we have free time and celebrate it together."

At the meantime, many organisations have started organising rallies and fairs to celebrate and preserve the festival. On the occasion, people dressed in Newari attire gather at Basantapur to participate in the events.

This year, a rally is being organised from Basantapur. It will pass through Tengal,, Chhetrapati, Thahiti, Ason, Indra Chowk, Ombahal, Lagan and Maru before returning to Basantapur.

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PM TO ADDRESS THE NATION TODAY



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda is set to address the nation on Tuesday. According to the Prime Minister's Secretariat, he will be addressing the nation from 5:00 pm.

He is scheduled to address the nation, marking the completion of one

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PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Students walking home from their school in Thaha Municipality of Makawanpur district.

Major parties agree to advance TRC Bill

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec 25:

A meeting of the top leaders of three major political parties held at the Prime Minister's official residence in Baluwatar this evening ended with an agreement to pass the Bill on Commission on Investigation of Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation (TRC) from the upcoming winter session of the Federal Parliament.

Parliamentary approval of the TRC Bill will be a breakthrough in completing the remaining tasks of the country's peace process.

According to the PM's Personal Secretary Ramesh Malla, the top leaders of the three major political parties agreed to advance the bill on Commission on Investigation of Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation, which is in the parliamentary committee and pass it from the winter session of the parliament with priority for making the laws relating to transitional justice.

Talking briefly to the media after the meeting, CPN (UML)'s parliamentary party whip Mahesh Bartaula said the top leaders agreed to make victim-centric laws.

"The UML is ready to go for a consensus if we are to make the victim-centric laws. The PM has expressed his readiness to address this issue from the winter session," Bartaula mentioned.

Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chair Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba, CPN (UML) Chair KP Sharma Oli, Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka, Minister for Law Dhanraj Gurung and other leaders of the three parties were present at the meeting summoned by the Prime Minister.

Smooth supply of fertilizer elates farmers

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The government has been giving priority to the supply of chemical fertilisers and other agricultural inputs in a bid to increase production and productivity of the agriculture sector.

In a year after the formation of the present government under the leadership of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on December 25, 2022, the government imported almost 500,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers.

According to the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development, the government has distributed more than 400,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers to the farmers in a year.

With the improvement in the supply of chemical fertilisers, the farmers across the country have been able to get the chemical fertilisers as per their needs during the time of paddy plantation and to grow winter crops like wheat and potatoes, said Sabnam Shivakoti, spokesperson for the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development.

Goma Adhikari of Panchkhal Municipality-7, Kavrepalanchowk, said that they received the required amount of chemical fertilisers for potato cultivation.

Recalling the acute shortage of chemical fertilisers during the paddy cultivation time in the summer and to grow potatoes in winter last year, she said that the farmers did not face any shortage of chemical fertilisers this year.

Last year, the farmers not only in Panchkhal but also elsewhere were forced to stand in queue for hours to get 5-10 kg of fertilisers.

"As farmers, we expect an easy supply of chemical fertilisers, seeds and tools and proper management of markets to sell our produce. So, I want to give thanks to the government for managing a smooth supply of chemical fertilisers. We also expect subsidies for these goods," she said.

One Year of Government

Even though the government has increased the supply of chemical fertilisers, the present supply is not enough. The government study showed that at least 700,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers are required annually.



The government has allocated Rs. 30 billion to provide subsidies to the farmers on chemical fertilisers.

Shivakoti said that the procurement process for chemical fertilisers would be improved and the supply and distribution process of the fertilisers would be made systematic and transparent.

The process of establishing a chemical fertiliser factory within the country has also moved ahead.

Development on crop seeds, livestock vaccination

According to the Ministry, the seed production cycle has been expanded by establishing 13 resource centres and producing 1,000 tonnes of source seeds of various crops.

In the last year, 22 varieties of various crops including rice, wheat, corn, and vegetables have been registered for source seeds and the seeds of six varieties have been released.

To provide technical services at farmers' doorstep, 397 people have been mobilised as agricultural graduates, veterinary doctors, agricultural technicians and animal service specialists at the local levels through conditional grants.

According to the Ministry, the area to cultivate fruits, vegetables, potatoes, coffee and spices has been expanded to 2,412 hectares by providing subsidies to attract farmers towards cash crop farming.

The minimum support price of rice has been fixed at Rs. 3,198 per quintal for coarse rice and Rs. 3,362 per quintal for medium rice and accordingly, 37,000 tonnes of paddy have been purchased through Food Management and Trading Company and 15,000 through cooperatives at the minimum support price.

The minimum purchase price of sugarcane this year has also been fixed at Rs. 635 per quintal.

During the year, around 181,965 crop and livestock insurance policies have been issued and crops and livestock worth Rs. 50 billion have been insured, according to the ministry.

A total of Rs. 2.12 billion, including Rs. 1.96 billion under livestock insurance and Rs. 159 million under agriculture insurance has been paid.

According to the ministry, the vaccination programme was conducted by producing 53.8 million doses of 13 different types of vaccines for the control of infectious diseases of livestock.

In the meantime, the government has facilitated the import of 1.37 million doses of vaccine to control lumpy skin disease, and around 351,000 animals have been vaccinated against the lumpy skin disease.

Rules, regulations and standards

According to the ministry, after approving the (First Amendment) Standard, 2079 regarding providing relief for items destroyed during bird flu control, an amount of Rs. 580 million

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I will do justice to all party leaders: Deuba

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Dec. 25

Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the party will maintain full justice while distributing the election tickets.



Inaugurating the NC Tanahun district conference in Damauli on Monday, Deuba said justice would be given to those who did not get the election tickets earlier and those who were not getting them now would get it in the future.

Deuba also inaugurated the BP Memorial Building constructed by the NC Tanahun District Committee.

Stressing for unity in the party by sacrificing differences, he said to build the party-unity strong, justice would be provided while distributing tickets in the election of the National Assembly.

Deuba also underlined the need for consensus among political parties stating that no party could garner a majority in the election due to the inclusive proportional system provisioned in the constitution.

"We have to strengthen the Federal Democratic Republic system by forging consensus," he said.

Deuba said although the NC did not garner a majority in the parliament due to the constitutional provision, it emerged as the largest party and it should move ahead with reconciliation.

"It is difficult for a single party to garner a majority in the parliament due to constitutional provision introduced to ensure representation of all castes, genders, communities and geographies, so there is no alternative to developing consensus with other parties to form the government," he said.

Deuba further stressed consensus between political parties to conclude the peace process and the crises facing the country.

Likewise, Deuba released a souvenir published by the NC Tahanun.

In the souvenir, the names of 1847 persons who donated to build the BP Memorial Building were mentioned. The building that covers an area of 8 aana of land was constructed at Rs. Rs. 17,200,000.

He also garlanded the BP's statute reaching BP Park in Byas Municipality-3, from where BP Koirala, in 1979, announced that the status of all Nepali should be made the same with one residence, a milking cow, a pair of oxen, enough food for morning and evening, money to educate children and buy medicines.

High level body sought to resolve power supply issue

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

The Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) has demanded formation of a high-level commission to resolve the arrears disputes of trunk and dedicated lines.

Issuing a press statement regarding a long-standing dispute related to the dedicated and trunk lines arrears on Monday, the FNCCI demanded a powerful commission to resolve the dispute between the Authority and the industrialists.

FNCCI showed its serious attention to the fact that power lines of industries were cut without resolving the disputes related to the payment of dedicated and trunk lines connected to industries.

The FNCCI demanded that a commission, having representatives also from private sector, should be formed to give an impartial opinion after analysing the past studies, current situation and Time of the Day (TOD) metres, among others.

The Federation has requested the Nepal Electricity Authority and other related agencies to reconnect the electricity supply of the industries Until a final decision is made on the issue. It also requested the NEA not to cut the lines of other industries.

"If this issue is not addressed immediately, industries will be shut down, and it will affect employment and revenue. During the current economic recession, the Federation is confident that the government will take initiatives to solve the problem by taking the issues of the private sector seriously," said the FNCCI.

Meanwhile, the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) has emphasised that the dispute over dedicated and trunk lines, which has been going on for a long time, should be resolved immediately through discussion rather than inviting a tussle.

Organising a press conference on Monday evening, President of CNI Rajesh Kumar Agrawal said that the disputes on the arrears of dedicated lines should be addressed adopting a middle way.

He said that it was not appropriate

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Newar community marks Yomari Punhi today

BY SUSHMA MAHARJAN
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

Yomari Punhi is a major festival of the Newars in Kathmandu. 'Yomari' means favourite confection in the Newari language. It is celebrated annually on the full moon of the Nepali month of Mangsir.

On the occasion, the people of the Newar community prepare a special delicacy called yomari, a closed cone-shaped cuisine made of rice flour filled with molasses and sesame seeds.

The festival also marks the end of the harvesting season.

Sunita Maharjan, a local from Kilagal, said that she celebrates by cleaning her house, performing puja and offering yomari to the god and goddess early in the morning. Afterwards, she prepares a feast for her family.

According to Maharjan, yomari is made from the flour of the first harvested paddy and offered to the paddy bhakari, a traditional container for storing food grains. This is done with prayers for the harvested grain to be sufficient for the family throughout the year. She said that people celebrate by performing 'tyo-si-tyo', a tradition, where groups visit houses in the



community singing folklore.

Upon their arrival, the house owners gift them yomari, fruits and other items and in return the group bless them with good fortune and life, Sunita said.

According to her, the tyo-si-tyo carries traditional and cultural values.

She said, "Newar people value sharing food and celebrating festivals with family and friends. Historically, yomari was a rare food prepared once a year. Thus, people used to play tyo-si-tyo and share yomari in the community."

Furthermore, making yomari is considered a way to showcase skills of housewives. Yomari's unique cone shape featuring a head and tail allows for artistic expression. The tail can be elongated and the head can be shaped into figures like birds, one horn and two horns or even flattened.

There is a belief that the longer the tail of the yomari, the longer the day will become from that day onward. Additionally, the delicacy is nutritionally valued since it is made of rice flour and sweet ingredients that help generate body heat.

Meanwhile, some people now celebrate the festival at their convenience due to busy lifestyles.

Sahayog Ranjit, a local, said that his family celebrates when they find free time. He said at least one festival falls every month in a Newar community. He said, "I and my family members are employed. We don't have enough time to prepare for the feast. Thus, we call a gathering of the closed family when we have free time and celebrate it together."

At the meantime, many organisations have started organising rallies and fairs to celebrate and preserve the festival. On the occasion, people dressed in Newari attire gather at Basantapur to participate in the events.

This year, a rally is being organised from Basantapur. It will pass through Tengal,, Chhetrapati, Thahiti, Ason, Indra Chowk, Ombahal, Lagan and Maru before returning to Basantapur.

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